Hello Again!

This prospect guide dropped back in March, and, well, a whole lot's gone down since then. Including the NFL Draft!

So, as promised, the guide got a little post-draft makeover. Portions of it remained the same — the Year 2 Model section is unchanged, as is the breakdown of what goes into the Z-Prospect Model — but there are important modifications to note:

- All draft profiles now include an updated Z-Prospect Model score along with their listed Draft Capital Delta.
- Relevant, higher-end rookies have an updated profile breakdown that talks about the player's new outlook. On a player's profile page, you'll see the word "update" before their blurb, designating new information about the player.
- The rookie rankings cheatsheet is redone.
- A new Z-Prospect Model cheatsheet was created to provide a snapshot of how the model views each player.
- A page full of notes was written to give the rankings some context.

Let's crush some rookie drafts.

LATE ROUND

PROSPECT GUIDE

JJ Zachariason | 2023 Edition

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About the Author

I'm not a traditional scout. Let's get that out of the way.

If you're reading this, you probably already knew that.

I'm a husband. I'm a dad. I'm a video gamer. I'm a Peloton rider. And I'm a professional fantasy football analyst.

I use the term "professional" loosely. I'm self-employed, and I podcast and break down fantasy football for a living. But I wear something other than gym shorts maybe…eight times per year?

Fantasy football has been my job for a decade now. I started at numberFire back in 2013 as the site's Editor-In-Chief, and after the company was bought by FanDuel in 2015, I worked there for seven years in the same role.

Today, I'm solo-operating Late-Round Fantasy Football. I'm a CEO. I'm kind of a big deal. (I'm not.)

I have a serious passion for fantasy football. It sounds silly — and extremely nerdy — but it's true. Some people like cars. Some like shoes. Some are really into film. For me, it's fantasy football.

My sincere goal is to help you win your fantasy football leagues. Not just by giving you answers to the test, though. That's not sustainable.

Instead, I want to teach you a successful process that's repeatable year after year. I want to explain the *why* and the *how.*

I want to show you what it takes to *consistently* win at fantasy football.

About This Guide

When I clicked send, the anxiety really hit.

It was the first time the results of my prospect model — the Z-Prospect Model — were out in the open.

In the past, I'd make one-off references to "my model" within my fantasy football analysis. Now, this guide and everything about that model was in the hands of a whole lot of fantasy football maniacs.

Now, people could *really* scrutinize my work.

That's a frightening feeling! It's not that I lack confidence in what's being produced. Quite the opposite. It's just that the fantasy football world, like most worlds, is filled with this expectation of being kind of…flawless. One mistake and someone could turn into a hater.

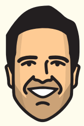
That's not how I operate, though.

In a sports world filled with black-and-white analysis — one where Dak Prescott goes from being a top-five quarterback one week to a cut candidate the next — I live in the gray area. Because that's the most logical place to live.

Last year's debut of this prospect guide is littered with examples of this gray-area thinking. Take Christian Watson, a player that the Z-Prospect Model pegged as an 84th percentile prospect. You'll learn more about what that means in a bit, but that's a good-not-elite score.

Did that rating mean he was incapable of becoming a high-end fantasy football wide receiver? Of course not. The details matter. The score was a good starting point, but there's far more to a player's outlook than a double-digit number. In his writeup within this guide — well, last year's version — it was noted that he was a higher-variance player who had a

Last Year's Prospect Guide



The 2022 Late-Round Prospect Guide was the first true Late-Round Fantasy Football deliverable. That certainly added to the stress.

good ceiling thanks to his athleticism. It was the floor that was concerning.

Or how about Isiah Pacheco? I screamed from the Twitter rooftops about Pacheco after he was selected in the seventh round by the Chiefs last year.

Did that mean that I saw *this* coming?

No! Not at all! The Z-Prospect Model liked Pacheco more than the consensus seemed to like him, and he was a low-risk dart throw in rookie drafts as a result. But a seventh-round running back should almost never be projected to become the starter for his offense.

> **We're not brain surgeons. We're not trying to put a human on Mars. We don't need to be super precise. We just need to be better than our leaguemates.**

Fantasy football is a probability-driven game. And that fact is what drove me to build the Z-Prospect Model in the first place.

You see, a handful of years ago, I had no methodical way of evaluating players entering the NFL. I had built a model, but my approach was…a little chaotic.

After a rough 2019 prospect season, I realized that something needed to change. I mean, I was out there promoting Andy Isabella as a legitimate rookie draft option.

Like I said, something needed to change.

So I got to work. I did a deeper dive into collegiate data, and I started doing more testing.

We Don't Talk About Pacheco

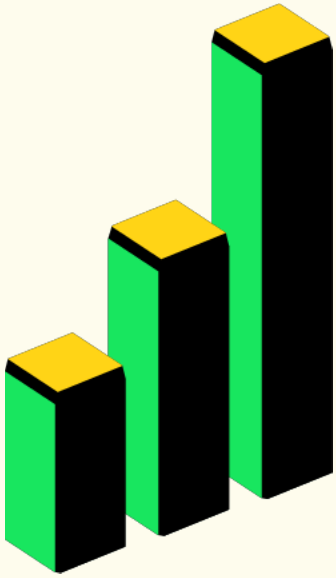
Members of the Late-Round Fantasy Football Discord didn't want their leaguemates to know that the Z-Prospect Model liked Isiah Pacheco last year. Referencing Encanto, we would sing, "We don't talk about Pacheco…"

The end result was two separate mathematical models — one for running backs, one for wide receivers — that assisted yours truly in finding fantasy football gems.

It's now time for those models to assist *you*.

You don't need to be a math whiz to understand the things that I'll talk about in this guide. You can leave the number-crunching to me.

But do prepare yourself: It's about to get nerdy.



The Z-Prospect Model

Overview

Fantasy football is a game about numbers. We care about production. So if we can nail down the most important inputs to that production, we'll be long-term winners.

Predicting what's going to happen on a football field isn't easy. No one should be telling you otherwise. Your goal, though, isn't to be perfect. It's to be better than your competition.

And, chances are, your competition probably doesn't have a sound process that they follow year in and year out for most things fantasy football. With a dynasty rookie draft, they're probably listening to people they trust, doing a little research themselves, and subjectively picking one guy over the next.

When we scout through numbers, we're able to formulate a trustworthy backbone. We can create a winning process that's repeatable.

So I approached my model building with a purpose. What was the very specific thing I wanted to solve?

After some thought, my brain put this out into the universe:

> The goal of the prospect models is to predict how well a running back and wide receiver will perform in fantasy football across his first three seasons in the league.

Was it random?

...Kind of?

The thought process behind the model's mission was that you're going to have a general idea of how good a player is after his first three years as a pro. Later breakouts happen, but not frequently.

The next question, then, was, "How?" As in, "How do you measure performance for a player across his first three seasons?"

You could look at raw fantasy points scored, but that wouldn't properly account for inevitable injuries. You could look at a player's best points per game average, but sometimes fluky seasons happen, too.

To meet in the middle, I decided to average out a player's best two seasons in points per game (in point per reception leagues) across the first three years of his career. That could've come in Year 2 and Year 3, or it could've happened in Year 1 and Year 2. Whatever top-two seasons were best in points per game, those seasons were averaged out and used for that historical player.

My Background

I always get asked if I studied something math-related in college. Nope. I've felt comfortable with numbers my whole life, but what I'm doing here isn't super complicated mathematically. I'm sure my high school math teachers would be proud, though.

Moving forward, I'll be referring to this as a player's "B2S" average, standing for "best two seasons."

The next thing I thought about was draft capital, or where a player was selected in the NFL Draft. If there was perfect correlation between draft capital and a player's B2S, then why build a model in the first place? You could just look at the NFL Draft and select players in your rookie draft based on that alone.

So, I tested it.

I took a giant sample of every wide receiver and running back who was either drafted or who attended the NFL Combine since 2006, and I threw them into a database. I then associated each player with their draft selection, where undrafted players got assigned the same number.

After seeing the correlation between draft capital and the B2S averages among hundreds and hundreds of players, I knew what needed to happen next.

> I needed to beat that correlation by a significant margin to make these models worthwhile.

To reiterate what I just said, if what I was building wouldn't be any more predictive than draft capital itself, what was the point?

My previous, iffier models used college production, some NFL Combine metrics, and player age to help determine who was good and who wasn't. Fundamentally, I knew that scouting through numbers was possible, and I knew a lot of the metrics I had previously utilized mattered to some degree.

> As I tend to say, only a fraction of productive college players are super productive in the NFL, but most super productive NFL players were productive in college.

There had to be data trends to lean on.

Without boring you to death, I ended up testing a ton of different metrics to see if I could beat draft capital. I got very close to my goal before having the realization that draft capital itself is an important piece to the puzzle here, too.

I mean, think about it: Where a player gets drafted has so much intrinsic value. A group of smart front-office people decided to choose that player.

That's free evaluation for us.

Not only that, but where a guy gets drafted can influence how quickly that player is able to find the field. When a coach or team invests strong draft capital in someone, chances are, they're going to really want that player to succeed.

So I plugged it into my model.

Voila!

With the help of draft capital, both the wide receiver and running back models predicted a player's best two seasons across his first three years way better than draft capital alone.

Oh, there's more.

Technically, we're not getting full use out of a model like this if it's simply beating out draft capital. In fantasy football, we're trying to crush our friends. Our coworkers. Strangers from hundreds of miles away who share the obsession.

We're not trying to be better than NFL teams.

So instead of seeing if the model was better at predicting a player's B2S than draft capital, I looked to see if it was more predictive than rookie draft average draft position (ADP), or where fantasy managers were selecting these players in drafts.

What I'm attempting to solve is different than what an NFL team is trying to solve. What I'm attempting to solve is *exactly* what other fantasy football managers are trying to solve.

Using My Fantasy League's historical ADP, the results were clear: The model I had built performed better than the public. Significantly better.

Phew.

The Z-Prospect Model (because my last name starts with the letter Z, and I'm really creative) was born.

The Inputs

You’re probably wondering what goes into this thing, huh?

Let’s start with running backs first.

The running back model produces a size score, which is based on a player’s Body Mass Index and weight. Are smaller running backs worse at football than larger running backs? Not necessarily. Do coaches give bigger-bodied backs more work in the NFL? Yes. Since volume drives fantasy football, that’s likely the reason size matters to this model.

Talent in Fantasy Football

Running back size is a good example of where we sometimes have to separate talent from what matters in fantasy football. Smaller running backs can be very effective for NFL teams, but those teams rarely feed those backs.

The model also utilizes what’s called a Speed Score, which is just a weight-adjusted 40-yard dash time. Bill Barnwell thought of the metric years ago after recognizing that not all 40-yard dashers are alike. It’s more impressive when a 240-pound running back runs a 4.4 40 versus a 190-pound one.

And the model agrees! Mostly. A Speed Score threshold of 90 needs to be hit — a modest number for any aspiring back — or else points are deducted from a running back’s prospect score. But if a running back hits, say, a 99th percentile Speed Score, it gets recognized the same way a 65th percentile Speed Score would.

Next, there’s age. Quite simply, older running backs entering the league get dinged a little more than someone who’s just 20 or 21 years old.

Finally, there are three main production metrics that the model utilizes to formulate a stat score: best-season reception share, best-season total touchdown share, and best-season total yards per team play. Each metric has a different weight and degree of usability within the model.

Even though they’re running backs, there’s a lot of signal that comes from best-season reception share, which measures the percentage of team receptions a specific running back accumulates.

My hypothesis for this is that receptions show versatility.

A lot of running backs with high reception shares don't actually go on to be top-notch pass-catchers in the NFL. Having a good reception share in college, though, tells us that these players were used in a lot of different ways, and that's evidence for talent.

Total touchdown share is self-explanatory, but it's the total number of touchdowns a running back has divided by his team's offensive touchdown tally. Of the three metrics, it's the least important, likely because touchdowns can be a little random.

And then there's total yards per team play, which is a way of showing how effective a player was within his own offense. What's cool about the metric is that it doesn't care about specifically volume or specifically efficiency. If a back averaged just four yards per carry but saw a ton of work, he's still got a shot to do well within the metric. If a player is more of a pass-catching specialist and was really efficient with his touches, he can still be fine in yards per team play, too.

Size, Speed Score, age, and those three production metrics. That's it. Add in draft capital, and we're cookin'.

The wide receiver model has a little more to it.

Age is in the running back model, but it matters a lot more at wide receiver.

There's a metric called Breakout Age, or the age when a college wide receiver hits a Dominator Rating of 20% or greater. What's Dominator Rating? Simply put, it's a number that measures a player's market share in his offense.

Breakout Age, then, is the age when a wide receiver sees a large share of his collegiate offense.

The correlation between Breakout Age and NFL performance exists

Breakout Age Calculations

You've likely seen fantasy analysts talk about Breakout Age before, but did you know that there's not one singular way to calculate it? I use a threshold that works for my model, but there's merit to other Breakout Age calculations.

because when a human being does something well at a young age, that human being is probably talented at doing that thing.

If a Freshman wide receiver is regularly beating upperclassman cornerbacks, it's impressive. That wide receiver hasn't had the same type of practice and experience, but he's still able to post great numbers.

Along the same lines of Breakout Age is whether or not a player declared early for the draft.

> **When a wide receiver leaves college for the NFL as a non-Senior, that's a sign that he's good at football. If he wasn't, he likely would've stayed in school.**

Since 2011, we've seen 49 wide receivers get selected in the first round of the NFL Draft. Of that group, 38 have played at least three seasons in the NFL (we're not counting players who were recently drafted).

Among those 38, 10 were non-early declares, playing a full four years in college.

Let's judge these players the same way the model does: by looking at a player's best two seasons average in points per game across his first three years. Or, as I called it earlier, B2S.

When we do that, the 10 wide receivers who didn't declare early see an average of 9.9 PPR points per game. Their best two seasons in points per game over their first three in the league averaged out to 9.9.

The remaining 28 wide receivers — the early-declare group — saw an average of 12.6.

Now, to be clear, if a wide receiver didn't declare early, he's not done for. Especially when you consider the fantasy football market.

You see, a lot of analysts and gamers understand the importance of early-declare status. And, sometimes, they lean on it too heavily.

Any repeat Late-Round Prospect Guide reader will remember that, last year, the Z-Prospect Model was really into Chris Olave. But Olave, as most know, wasn't an early-declare wide receiver.

Oh, the horror!

This stresses the importance of using the model as a foundation. When you pick apart individual traits without seeing the greater picture, you end up missing out on stud wide receivers like Olave.

Does early-declare status matter? Yes. Is it everything? Absolutely not.

Now, unlike the running back model, NFL Combine athleticism measurables don't matter for wide receivers. And while size is an input, it's not hugely important. At least compared to running backs.

That may sound crazy. Shouldn't a bigger-bodied, physically-gifted wide receiver be highly sought after?

Not necessarily.

Subjectively, you probably would want an enormous and athletic wide receiver on your team over a tiny and slow one.

But it's very rare for completely unathletic wide receivers to get drafted early in the first place.

Part of the reason size and athleticism isn't a big deal in the wide receiver model is because it's likely already captured in draft capital. And draft capital is in the wide receiver model.

Not only that, but wide receivers do different jobs on a football field. Cooper Kupp doesn't win the same way DK Metcalf does. Keenan Allen doesn't do the same things Mike Evans does. Metcalf and Evans are

more physically dominant, and even though they're highly productive as pros, Kupp and Allen are, too.

If a player completely bombs the NFL Combine — and I'm talking like, 15th percentile marks across the board — you'd probably want to remove that player from your consideration set. Chances are, though, that same player won't have good draft capital, and he likely wouldn't have had the best college production profile. So, in the end, the lack of athleticism and size doesn't matter much because more important factors weren't going his way.

This is why it was difficult to knock Devonta Smith's size when he was entering the league in 2021. Was his low BMI a concern? Slightly, I suppose. But Smith had an absurd production profile while being selected 10th overall. To me, the biggest knock was the fact that he wasn't an early-declare wide receiver, not the fact that he's a skinny dude. He ended up grading out as an elite player in the model.

Moving on, there are three production statistics the wide receiver model focuses on for a player's stat score: best-season receptions per game, best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt, and best-season touchdown share.

On its own, receptions per game isn't that great of a metric. It doesn't even factor in team offense or tendencies — it's not a market share-related statistic.

My guess as to why it helps the wide receiver model is because it's working alongside best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is similar to total yards per team play at running back in that it's a market share statistic that kind of looks like an efficiency one. Big plays can admittedly skew the results of the metric — albeit slightly — so my guess is that adding in receptions per game provides a baseline for volume.

To put that in a more consumable way, if a player is actually distorting his receiving yards per team play number through big plays, receptions per game can help bring things back to Earth. Because it's going to be

Z-Prospect Model Stat Scores

You may see references to "stat score" throughout the guide, and all it means is a player's score when looking solely at production metrics.

hard to create monster plays reception after reception. And if the wideout *is* doing that reception after reception, then he's probably a good wide receiver.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is the metric that gets the most weight in the model. The one that gets the least amount of love is touchdown share, which, just like the running back model, is probably because touchdowns bring some variance.

So we've got Breakout Age, early-declare status, size, draft capital, and three production metrics. The final two things that go into the wide receiver model are what I call "conference factor" and "teammate factor." Wideouts who played in specific conferences get additional points added to their prospect score. That seems to matter more for the position than at running back. And receivers who played with good teammates in college get a slight bump, too.

The Outputs

The nice part about prospecting through data is that you can test and see if a model works.

	Wide Receiver (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	26%	74%	58%	42%	26%	16%	5%
90-95	56%	44%	32%	28%	16%	4%	4%
85-90	50%	50%	38%	25%	13%	4%	0%
80-85	52%	48%	44%	24%	12%	0%	0%
75-80	83%	17%	13%	4%	0%	0%	0%
70-75	88%	12%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	87%	13%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	93%	7%	7%	4%	0%	0%	0%

The table above shows the results of the wide receiver model from 2011 through 2020. The left column gives you the percentile bucket that a prospect fell into within the Z-Prospect Model, and the middle of the table tells you the percentage of players from that percentile grouping to have averaged a particular points per game mark in B2S.

Let's pretend a wide receiver scored 10, 12, and 17 PPR points per game across his first three seasons in the league. We'd throw out that average of 10 (his lowest points per game output) and completely focus on the 12 and 17 in order to capture his B2S. The average of those two numbers is 14.5, placing that wide receiver in the "14+" bucket but not the "16+" one.

Again, that's what the B2S acronym is all about.

As you can see, the wide receiver model isn't spotless. In fact, players ranking in the 80th to 90th percentile have fared similarly to players who ranked in the 90th to 95th. It doesn't mean the model is wrong or bad — that particular example is most likely due to sample size variance.

What's most important with a table like this is the general trends.

There's a very clear drop-off when a player is unable to hit the 80th percentile as a prospect. And if a wideout is a 95th percentile incoming rookie, his chance of hitting big is pret-tay, pret-tay good.

The running back visual looks a lot like the wide receiver one:

Running Back (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)

Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	18%	82%	76%	65%	53%	41%	29%
90-95	44%	56%	33%	22%	6%	6%	0%
85-90	22%	78%	56%	39%	33%	17%	6%
80-85	76%	24%	6%	6%	6%	6%	0%
75-80	69%	31%	13%	6%	6%	0%	0%
70-75	75%	25%	19%	6%	6%	6%	0%
65-70	82%	18%	9%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	82%	18%	6%	0%	0%	0%	0%

Each offseason, I test and see if there are any new ways to make these models more predictive. A focus this offseason — and this will come in handy given this year's running back class — surrounded running back weight.

Previously, BMI was the weight-related metric in the running back model. But, now, there's also a focus on raw weight because it does get signal. And the model is now better at forecasting as a result.

The running back model's output shares some similarities to the wide receiver one, except we're a little more focused on the 85th percentile or better instead of the 80th.

These tables are important to keep in mind as you read through this guide. I'll be providing percentile scores for prospects, and you can use those scores to get a rough idea of a player's hit rate.

Draft Capital Delta

I've talked a lot about draft capital and its importance to the models. Naturally, because it's an input, there's a connection between how the model sees players and where they were drafted. Especially at running back, where draft capital matters more.

Not only that, but good players are often beloved in both film evaluation and numbers-based analysis. Ja'Marr Chase broke the Z-Prospect Model a couple of years ago, but traditional scouting saw him as an insanely good prospect, too. There's obvious overlap in the way the model may view a player and the way the NFL — draft capital — does.

What about when there's not?

Well, let me tell you a little story about a running back named Isiah Pacheco.

Anyone who read this guide a year ago was likely targeting Pacheco with a later-round rookie pick. I mean, the writeup for him literally said, "Pacheco should be a top late-round target in rookie drafts."

As I said earlier, the expectation for Pacheco wasn't that he'd become one of the key running backs for the high-powered Chiefs' offense as a

seventh-round rookie running back. The hit rate for seventh-round running backs is about as good as an episode of *Friends*. (Stop it. That show is bad.) Expecting that would've been horrible process.

In truth, Pacheco had a 48th percentile score in the Z-Prospect Model. He was technically a below-average running back in the sample we're working with.

But he was also the 251st selection in the NFL Draft. And that's key.

Among running backs in the Z-Prospect Model database, that draft capital ranked in the 38th percentile. (Remember, there are undrafted players in there, so while the 251st overall selection is certainly late, it could've been far worse.)

That means Pacheco looked better in the model than he did through the lens of the NFL Draft. The difference between his draft capital and his Z-Prospect Model score was roughly +10.4%. That favorable deviation was one of the many reasons he became a target in rookie drafts last year.

This difference in prospect score percentile and draft capital percentile is what I aptly call Draft Capital Delta. And it can be a helpful tool.

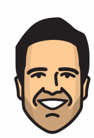
It's just not everything. Transparency is key here, and, admittedly, Isiah Pacheco did not have the best Draft Capital Delta in last year's running back class. Tyler Badie and Kevin Harris both ranked ahead of him.

But that's OK! We're not drafting strictly off of Draft Capital Delta. We're merely recognizing that players with higher Draft Capital Deltas will become values more often than players with lower ones.

Because they really do. In the Z-Prospect Model dataset, there are 31 running backs who were drafted while also seeing a Draft Capital Delta above 5%, all while playing three years in the league. Of those 31, 7 were able to hit a double-digit B2S. Meaning 22.6% of these players saw 10-plus PPR points per game when averaging their top-two seasons during their first three in the league.

Among the running backs who were at -5% or worse — so on the

The Best Draft Capital Delta



The running back with the best Draft Capital Delta in the Z-Prospect Model's history is Aaron Jones.

negative end — that number is 3 of 43, or less than 7%.

The same results hold true at wide receiver. Of wide receivers in the model who were drafted, who've finished up their third year, and who had a Draft Capital Delta above 5%, 15.4% had a double-digit B2S. On the flip side, just 9.0% of wide receivers with a Draft Capital Delta worse than -5% hit that mark.

The metric is not an end-all. It's just a piece to the puzzle. And it's a piece that can be mighty helpful at the extremes.

Adding Subjectivity

These models are cool and all, but I'll be the first to tell you that they won't give you all the answers. There are actually some fundamental flaws to them.

Look no further than Jaylen Waddle a couple of years ago. Coming out of Alabama, Waddle didn't have a very good production profile. He didn't have a great Breakout Age, and all three production metrics were below average.

Waddle had a Z-Prospect score that placed him in the 96th percentile. Nothing wrong with that. But given he went sixth overall, he had a Draft Capital Delta of -3.0%, telling us that he was overdrafted.

In that 2021 draft class, Ja'Marr Chase, Devonta Smith, Rashod Bateman, and Elijah Moore all had better or similar prospect scores compared to Waddle. My rankings, however, placed Waddle third at wide receiver. He was in a tier above Bateman and Moore.

Why?

Nuance. That's why.

> Seeing how a player looks in a model can be helpful, but I'll never tell you to stop there. Looking at a player's journey and — gasp — *watching* the player play is always a solid idea as well.

With Waddle, there were clear reasons as to why his analytical profile was lacking. During his Freshman year, he outproduced first-round wide receiver talent. His snaps did dip as a Sophomore, but then as a Junior — his final collegiate season — he was injured after his first four games played. Through those four games, he had more receiving yards for Alabama than Heisman winner Devonta Smith.

Should we make small-sample assumptions? No, of course not. We can't say that Waddle would've posted better numbers than Smith had he played the entirety of his Junior season.

We just don't have to think in such a black and white way.

The fact that Waddle still ranked as a 96th percentile prospect in the Z-Prospect Model despite the poor production profile was telling. Imagine a world where he didn't get hurt during his final season! It wasn't hard to give him a subjective boost in rankings as a result.

Considering the Waddle example, you may be wondering why the model doesn't use per-game numbers for some of the metrics.

To be blunt, it's because it doesn't matter.

Looking at yards per team pass attempt in games played, for instance, is good context to have, but you run into issues where a player's top season is all twisted because of a small sample size.

I've tested it, and full-season numbers work better within this model. If more detail is needed, I can always add subjective context.

Drake London's Profile

One player who didn't look all that hot in yards per team pass attempt last season was Drake London. He had an injury-filled collegiate career. But that context was noted in his prospect guide profile, and he still had a seriously great Z-Prospect score.

Another good illustration of where my model and rankings disagreed was with Dameon Pierce last season. He was a 68th percentile prospect entering the league thanks to a pretty mediocre production profile in college.

But he was clearly not as bad as the profile suggested. According to Pro Football Focus, Pierce had the highest rushing grade in all of college football in 2021. He was also an incredible tackle-breaker.

That forced him up my rankings.

It's OK to view players differently than how a model views them.

Let me give you one last example. Many analysts have found success looking at return yardage as an input for wide receiver prospects. If a wideout had a lot of return yards on punts and kicks, then it's probably a sign that the wide receiver has ability — coaches put their best play-makers in those return positions.

My model doesn't have return yardage as an input, but when I'm perusing prospects, it's something I keep in the back of my mind as a positive indicator.

There's nothing wrong with doing that. There's nothing wrong with adding a little subjectivity to your evaluation as you use the model as your guide.

Positional Focus

So far, you've learned all about the inner workings of the Z-Prospect Model. You know which metrics are most meaningful to it, you can see the importance of draft capital, and you're aware that it's not perfect.

Before sending you off to read about the 2023 class, you may be questioning why the emphasis here has solely been on running backs and wide receivers. And that's a reasonable question to ask!

As you know, running backs and wide receivers are the lifeblood of

A Tight End Model

I worked for hours on a potential tight end model this offseason, but to no avail. If you want a quick and dirty way to evaluate them analytically: Grab athletic tight ends who get drafted early.

fantasy football. You start more of them — they're higher in demand — so they're the central pieces to the game.

That alone was the reason I went on the journey of building running back and wide receiver models. They just matter more.

But I've also started the creation of quarterback and tight end models. It just hasn't gotten very far.

There could be something in the future, but for now, all the love is being given to backs and wideouts.

2023 Prospect Profiles

Overview

It's rare for a running back or wide receiver to emerge as a star in the league without an NFL Combine invite. It certainly happens — Austin Ekeler and Adam Thielen both became studs after being skipped over.

But just because there are exceptions to the rule doesn't mean the rule is invalid.

Strictly from a probability perspective, for fantasy football purposes, we should care most about the players who were invited to the NFL Combine. Period. That shouldn't be debated.

So that's where the focus is at for these prospect profiles.

There were 26 running backs invited to this year's NFL Combine. There were 50 wide receivers who were awarded the same honor.

> I profiled them. Every single one of them. I looked at their analytical profiles, and I studied the type of player they may be at the next level.

These outlooks are bound to change post-draft — and when they do, I'll send you an updated version of this guide — but it's never a bad idea to have a good grasp on a class before the draft happens.

Key Terms

Z-Prospect Score: The score — often in percentile form — given to an incoming rookie in the Z-Prospect Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the Z-Prospect Overview section of this guide.

B2S: The Z-Prospect Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The percentile difference between a player's Z-Prospect score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. Anything under 0 means the player was overdrafted, and anything over 0 means the player was underdrafted.

Speed Score: A concept developed by Bill Barnwell to help appropriately weight 40-yard dash times based on a player's size. In the Z-Prospect Model, anything under 90 at running back is a red flag.

Statistical Comparables: Players in history who appear to have similar analytical profiles to the player being analyzed. This is based on things like size, early-declare status, and production metrics.

Z-Prospect Model Cheatsheet

Running Back				Wide Receiver			
	Player	Z-Prospect	Delta		Player	Z-Prospect	Delta
1	Bijan Robinson	98.5%	0.5%	1	Jaxon Smith-Njigba	95.8%	0.2%
2	Jahmyr Gibbs	98.1%	-0.2%	2	Jordan Addison	94.2%	0.3%
3	Zach Charbonnet	90.8%	-1.0%	3	Quentin Johnston	93.4%	-1.4%
4	Tank Bigsby	85.4%	3.6%	4	Zay Flowers	92.9%	-1.4%
5	Kendre Miller	83.5%	-2.7%	5	Josh Downs	86.7%	8.5%
6	Devon Achane	81.0%	-2.2%	6	Jonathan Mingo	84.2%	-5.8%
7	Tyjae Spears	78.8%	-4.6%	7	Jalin Hyatt	83.9%	4.3%
8	Israel Abanikanda	70.8%	5.6%	8	Jayden Reed	83.4%	-3.1%
9	Evan Hull	69.6%	12.9%	9	Marvin Mims	82.2%	0.2%
10	Roschon Johnson	64.5%	-10.2%	10	Rashee Rice	78.1%	-6.9%
11	Chase Brown	59.1%	-0.2%	11	Tank Dell	76.8%	-3.9%
12	Deuce Vaughn	54.0%	7.8%	12	Cedric Tillman	75.6%	-3.9%
13	Chris Rodriguez	47.4%	-4.1%	13	Kayshon Boutte	70.7%	18.8%
14	Sean Tucker	47.2%	11.2%	14	Parker Washington	67.2%	14.3%
15	Eric Gray	44.5%	-13.1%	15	Tyler Scott	65.1%	1.0%
16	DeWayne McBride	44.3%	0.0%	16	Trey Palmer	59.5%	8.8%
17	Zach Evans	36.3%	-9.2%	17	Michael Wilson	58.8%	-14.8%
18	Tavion Thomas	25.5%	-10.5%	18	Charlie Jones	53.9%	-11.3%
19	Kenny McIntosh	23.8%	-16.8%	19	AT Perry	53.5%	3.9%
20	Tiyon Evans	19.2%	-16.8%	20	Dontayvion Wicks	52.6%	-7.2%
21	Keaton Mitchell	18.0%	-18.0%	21	Tre Tucker	51.0%	-21.7%
22	Mohamed Ibrahim	17.8%	-18.2%	22	Xavier Hutchinson	50.3%	2.9%
23	Travis Dye	13.1%	-22.9%	23	Puka Nacua	46.5%	-7.9%
24	Deneric Prince	11.9%	-24.1%	24	Andrei Iosivas	45.0%	-2.1%
25	Camerun Peoples	11.4%	-24.6%	25	Demario Douglas	42.9%	-2.4%

Post-Draft Rankings Cheatsheet

	Single-QB Top-48				Superflex Top-48		
	Player	Pos	Tier		Player	Pos	Tier
1	Bijan Robinson	RB	1	1	Bijan Robinson	RB	1
2	Jahmyr Gibbs	RB	2	2	Anthony Richardson	QB	2
3	Jaxon Smith-Njigba	WR	3	3	Bryce Young	QB	2
4	Jordan Addison	WR	4	4	CJ Stroud	QB	2
5	Quentin Johnston	WR	4	5	Jahmyr Gibbs	RB	3
6	Zay Flowers	WR	4	6	Jaxon Smith-Njigba	WR	4
7	Anthony Richardson	QB	5	7	Jordan Addison	WR	5
8	Zach Charbonnet	RB	5	8	Quentin Johnston	WR	5
9	Devon Achane	RB	5	9	Zay Flowers	WR	5
10	Dalton Kincaid	TE	5	10	Will Levis	QB	6
11	Bryce Young	QB	6	11	Zach Charbonnet	RB	6
12	CJ Stroud	QB	6	12	Devon Achane	RB	6
13	Jayden Reed	WR	6	13	Dalton Kincaid	TE	6
14	Marvin Mims	WR	6	14	Jayden Reed	WR	7
15	Kendre Miller	RB	6	15	Marvin Mims	WR	7
16	Jonathan Mingo	WR	6	16	Kendre Miller	RB	7
17	Sam LaPorta	TE	6	17	Jonathan Mingo	WR	7
18	Josh Downs	WR	7	18	Sam LaPorta	TE	7
19	Jalin Hyatt	WR	7	19	Hendon Hooker	QB	7
20	Roschon Johnson	RB	8	20	Josh Downs	WR	8
21	Rashee Rice	WR	8	21	Jalin Hyatt	WR	8
22	Michael Mayer	TE	8	22	Roschon Johnson	RB	9
23	Tank Bigsby	RB	9	23	Rashee Rice	WR	9
24	Tyjae Spears	RB	9	24	Michael Mayer	TE	9
25	Luke Musgrave	TE	9	25	Tank Bigsby	RB	10
26	Cedric Tillman	WR	9	26	Tyjae Spears	RB	10
27	Israel Abanikanda	RB	10	27	Luke Musgrave	TE	10
28	Chase Brown	RB	10	28	Cedric Tillman	WR	10
29	Kayshon Boutte	WR	10	29	Israel Abanikanda	RB	11
30	Tank Dell	WR	10	30	Chase Brown	RB	11
31	Tyler Scott	WR	10	31	Kayshon Boutte	WR	11
32	Tucker Kraft	TE	11	32	Tank Dell	WR	11
33	Trey Palmer	WR	11	33	Tyler Scott	WR	11
34	Puka Nacua	WR	11	34	Tucker Kraft	TE	12
35	Zach Evans	RB	12	35	Trey Palmer	WR	12
36	Darnell Washington	TE	12	36	Puka Nacua	WR	12
37	DeWayne McBride	RB	12	37	Zach Evans	RB	13
38	Deuce Vaughn	RB	12	38	Darnell Washington	TE	13
39	Evan Hull	RB	13	39	Stetson Bennett	QB	13
40	Luke Schoonmaker	TE	13	40	DeWayne McBride	RB	13
41	Michael Wilson	WR	13	41	Deuce Vaughn	RB	13
42	AT Perry	WR	13	42	Evan Hull	RB	14
43	Eric Gray	RB	14	43	Luke Schoonmaker	TE	14
44	Xavier Hutchinson	WR	14	44	Michael Wilson	WR	14
45	Charlie Jones	WR	14	45	AT Perry	WR	14
46	Brenton Strange	TE	14	46	Eric Gray	RB	15
47	Parker Washington	WR	14	47	Xavier Hutchinson	WR	15
48	Dontayvion Wicks	WR	15	48	Charlie Jones	WR	15

Rankings Notes

- **Anthony Richardson** may not have been the first quarterback drafted, but with Shane Steichen and his athletic profile, he has the highest ceiling at quarterback in this class.
- The tiebreaker being used for **CJ Stroud** versus **Bryce Young** is draft capital.
- There may be some concern about **Jahmyr Gibbs**' size, but at the very least, he's going to likely maintain his dynasty value best year over year compared to any of the wide receivers in the class.
- There's a new tight end model that's not quite ready to be released, and it likes **Sam LaPorta** most in this class. Had **Dalton Kincaid** tested, it would've been close. Kincaid gets the TE1 spot because of landing spot, but LaPorta is legit.
- **Luke Musgrave** is great in the new model, too. It likes him more than **Michael Mayer** thanks to better athleticism. That's why they're in the same tier.
- This tight end class is really, really strong. Just keep in mind that they don't appreciate in value as well as running back and wide receiver from Year 1 to Year 2. The rankings reflect this.
- Landing spot rarely dictates my rankings, but **Devon Achane** to Miami is an exception to that rule. The model has him as a decent prospect anyway, and the model is recognizing his size.
- Things become a lot more volatile after the **Zay Flowers** range. Pay attention to tiers, because there's a good chance moving back a bit in rookie drafts after that point in time is the move.
- The **Jayden Reed**, **Marvin Mims**, **Josh Downs**, **Kendre Miller**, and **Jonathan Mingo** tier really comes down to preference. If your team desperately needs a running back, it's totally fine to take Miller over any of those wide receivers.
- That tier is also one that the Z-Prospect Model seems to like. If you can trade back into that tier, it might be beneficial.
- One of the harder decisions was **Tank Bigsby** versus **Tyjae Spears**. I sided with the model, but there's no denying that Spears could have much better 2024 opportunity. But keep Spears' injury history in mind.
- With more thought, **Roschon Johnson** might be a really strong target in rookie drafts. His competition isn't locked in, and he's got the best pass-catching chops in that Bears backfield.

Bijan Robinson

RB • Texas Longhorns (Atlanta Falcons)

98.6%	+0.5%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Breece Hall** **Ezekiel Elliott** **Najee Harris**

Update: We don't often get a top-10 running back selection in the NFL Draft, but we did this year when the Falcons drafted Bijan Robinson. His pre- to post-draft percentile ranking didn't change a ton, but the landing spot could've been *a lot* worse than Atlanta.

Falcons running backs low-key crushed it last year. Among qualified backs, per Pro Football Focus data, Tyler Allgeier was sixth-best in yards after contact per attempt, Caleb Huntley ranked 10th, and Cordarrelle Patterson was in the top-30. All three ranked in the top-15 in numberFire's success rate metric, too.

One could argue that Arthur Smith's scheme would've allowed Atlanta to go in a different direction with their eighth-overall pick, but from a fantasy perspective, it shows us that Robinson is capable of going nuts.

Robinson's Draft Capital Delta isn't huge because early-round picks won't have big numbers within the statistic. His prospect score places him elite company, though. He's the top pick in rookie drafts this year. Don't overthink it.

Jahmyr Gibbs

RB • Alabama Crimson Tide (Detroit Lions)

98.0%	-0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**199**
Statistical Comparables:	**Giovani Bernard** **Isaiah Pead** **Alvin Kamara**

Update: The Lions snagged Jahmyr Gibbs much earlier than expected, and it gave his prospect score a huge boost. It may seem weird seeing Gibbs’ score so close to Bijan Robinson’s, but it’s mostly because these scores are represented by percentiles. Gibbs’ raw score is more in line with players like Najee Harris and Travis Etienne, two backs who went in the mid-20s.

The main concern with Gibbs is his size, and that hasn’t changed. From 2011 to 2020, we saw 18 running backs get drafted in the top-100 while weighing in under 210 pounds. Of those 18, just 3 (16.7%) hit 14 or more PPR points per game in a season across one of their first three years in the league. That number is 25 of 54 (46.3%) when focusing on the players at or above 210 pounds.

Gibbs also landed on a team that’s likely looking to divvy up the backfield. The Lions signed David Montgomery to a three-year deal, and his guaranteed money should keep him there for at least two of those three. It’s unlikely Gibbs becomes the goal-line guy for them given Montgomery’s presence.

With all this being said, it’s clear that Gibbs is a unique, outlier-type prospect. He joins Saquon Barkley and Christian McCaffrey as the only first-round running backs since 2011 with a best-season reception share above 17%. And prior to Gibbs going in the first, only CMC had multiple collegiate seasons with a reception share above 15% among the group.

Gibbs is an elite pass-catcher with crazy speed, and first-round backs have a great track record. You should feel fine about taking him as early as the 1.02 in your single-quarterback formats, even with the size concerns.

Zach Charbonnet

RB • UCLA Bruins (Seattle Seahawks)

90.8%	-1.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**214**
Statistical Comparables:	**Sony Michel** **Kareem Hunt** **Tevin Coleman**

Update: The draft capital was there for Zach Charbonnet. The landing spot was not.

Pete Carroll loves himself some running backs, and for a second straight year, Seattle took a back with a second-round pick. And while this year’s back isn’t as good as last year’s, he’s still a great prospect.

Charbonnet has the rare combination of size and a good receiving profile. He’s just the fifth running back since 2011 to get drafted in Round 2 with a best-season reception share north of 12% while weighing more than 210 pounds. The other four were Joe Mixon, Le’Veon Bell, D’Andre Swift, and Daniel Thomas.

Clearly, the problem here is that Charbonnet is now sharing a backfield with Kenneth Walker. If you’ve read Walker’s Year 2 profile, then you already know that he struggled to gain positive yards in 2022. And he wasn’t used heavily as a pass-catcher.

That’s where Charbonnet can help. Walker’s a home-run-hitting running back, and he can carry a big workload. But Charbonnet can complement that as more of a grinder and pass-catcher out of the backfield.

It’s certainly a rough landing spot for Charbonnet. We’re unlikely going to see him become a high-end fantasy back without a Walker injury. And it’s not like Walker’s going to be off the team in a year. So even though the model likes him, you’ve got to subjectively move Charbonnet down your rankings post-draft.

Pete Carroll strikes again.

Devon Achane

RB • Texas A&M Aggies (Miami Dolphins)

81.0%	-2.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**188**
Statistical Comparables:	**Isaiah Pead** **Tyler Ervin** **Justin Jackson**

Update: There was one obvious landing spot for Devon Achane in this year’s draft that would’ve made him a much more attractive fantasy option.

And he landed there.

Going to Mike McDaniel and the Dolphins is perfect. Absolutely perfect. His speed can kill defenses in the outside zone scheme, as evidenced by previous running backs in the Shanahan system like Elijah Mitchell (4.40 40-yard dash) and Raheem Mostert (4.43). Both Mitchell and Mostert entered the league as smaller backs, too, weighing in at 201 and 195 pounds, respectively.

The size thing *is* still an issue, of course. Achane is only 188 pounds. Since 2011 — perhaps beyond — we haven’t seen a sub-190-pound back get to 100 carries in a single season. Tarik Cohen’s the only one who’s seen any significant fantasy production, too.

But of the 19 running backs in the prospect database who were under that 190-pound mark prior to this year’s draft, none were top-100 picks like Achane. Tarik Cohen had the best draft capital from that subset, and he went 119th overall.

And he just happened to be the back who performed best.

Achane might not see a bell-cow workload, but he has a chance to be insanely efficient in one of the fastest offenses we’ve ever seen. There aren’t obvious ways to go at running back in your rookie drafts, so betting on Achane as a Dolphin isn’t a tough thing to do.

Deuce Vaughn

RB • Kansas State Wildcats (Dallas Cowboys)

54.0%	+7.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’5”**
Weight:	**179**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tarik Cohen** **Jacquizz Rodgers** **Donnel Pumphrey**

Update: There’s no denying Deuce Vaughn’s production profile. His stat score isn’t only the best in this year’s draft class, but it’s the best in the entire Z-Prospect database. Vaughn was that dude at Kansas State.

The problem? Well, with the pre-draft version of this guide, the problem was only his size. He’s 5’5’’, matching JJ Taylor as the shortest back to either get drafted or go to the NFL Combine since 2011. At 176 pounds, he’s unlikely to carry a huge workload in the league.

Between the release of that guide and now, Vaughn ran his 40-yard dash at his Pro Day. And he clocked in at 4.56, giving him one of the lowest Speed Scores in the database.

You’ve got problems when a smaller back isn’t fast.

Vaughn still comes out with a positive Draft Capital Delta because the production was so absurd, but his overall prospect score as a sixth-round pick isn’t anything special. He did land in Dallas, though, and he could see work in that offense immediately. The team’s depth chart – as it stands today – consists of just Tony Pollard, Malik Davis, Rico Dowdle, Ronald Jones, and Vaughn.

If Vaughn had shown up and ran a sub-4.5 40, things might look different. He’s merely a low-ceiling, medium-floor late-round rookie pick now.

Sean Tucker

RB • Syracuse Orange (Undrafted)

47.2%	+11.2%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5'9"**
Weight:	**207**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jeremy McNichols** **Eno Benjamin** **Dalvin Cook**

Update: Sean Tucker had unfortunate medicals, and it's likely the reason he went undrafted. He's got one of the best production profiles from an undrafted running back that you'll find, with top-eight numbers in all three production metrics within this class. That's resulting in him being a top-10 undrafted free agent that the prospect model's ever seen.

We know UDFAs don't work out at a very high rate, but in deep leagues, Tucker could still be considered. It appears as though he signed with the Buccaneers after the draft, and they've got a depth chart that's climbable.

Tank Bigsby

RB • Auburn Tigers (Jacksonville Jaguars)

85.4%	+3.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**DeMarco Murray Charles Sims Jeremy Langford**

Update: Tank Bigsby's size and best-season reception share isn't easy to find. There've only been eight running backs since 2011 to have a best-season reception share at or above 18% while weighing in at 210-plus pounds. Three of those backs had top-100 draft capital: David Johnson, Charles Sims, and Rachaad White.

Bigsby makes four.

That's certainly not bad company to be part of. And, if you extend that draft capital filter to the top-130, you get Tony Pollard in there, too. Pretty sweet.

Unfortunately, Bigsby fell to Jacksonville where he'll be competing for touches with Travis Etienne. He won't be getting a backfield to himself. But at least Etienne ranked well outside the top-10 last year in running back rush share per game, and we saw Jacksonville utilize James Robinson a bit at the start of the season in order to keep Etienne fresh. Head coach Doug Pederson has openly said that the team needs two or three guys to make the run game work.

Just don't go crazy. Bigsby's got a really solid prospect score, but he's going to be playing with Etienne for at least the next two seasons. Chances are, he'll be a flex play at best with the chance to step into a starter role with an injury. That's something that should be on your dynasty roster, but not something you need to prioritize in your rookie draft.

Eric Gray

RB • Oklahoma Sooners (New York Giants)

44.5%	-13.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'10"**
Weight:	**207**
Statistical Comparables:	**Matt Dayes** **Sony Michel** **Kyle Hicks**

Update: Eric Gray got some love in this guide pre-draft, and then he tested at his Pro Day. He ran a 4.62 40-yard dash, giving him a Pro Day-adjusted Speed Score south of 90. When that's the case, running backs get dinged pretty hard in the model.

If you were to *not* adjust his 40 time for it being a Pro Day, he would've been *just* over that 90 Speed Score mark. And his prospect score would've been in the 59th percentile or so.

But we've got to trust the process here.

Gray going to the Giants is pretty interesting. The G-Men don't have anyone of significance behind Saquon Barkley on the depth chart, and Barkley himself may not be around in 2024. So Gray has a shot to appreciate in value from 2023 to 2024 if things break right.

Strictly as a prospect, though, there just doesn't seem to be enough upside to Gray's profile. And that's coming from someone who typically would *love* his 16.8% best-season reception share and 207-pound frame.

He'll probably end up going where he should in rookie drafts.

Zach Evans

RB • Mississippi Rebels (Los Angeles Rams)

36.3%	-9.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**202**
Statistical Comparables:	**Zamir White** **Jordan Scarlett** **Nick Brossette**

Update: The Z-Prospect Model and Zach Evans don’t get along very well. All three of his production metrics in the model are well below average, and he weighed in at just 202 pounds at the combine. We just don’t see successful running backs with that kind of profile very often.

To be fair to Evans, he did play alongside strong talent in college, and he wasn’t always able to stay healthy. But we can’t make too many excuses here. The fact is, there’ve been 103 running backs with a stat score as low as his in the model’s history. And fewer than 6% of those players ended up scoring 10-plus PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons in the NFL. The only player to do it more than once was Chris Carson, who had plenty of size on Evans.

Going to the Rams *could* offer up some rookie-season opportunity for Evans. If he shows up, Cam Akers is a free agent next year, so Evans could hypothetically walk into the 2024 season as LA’s starter.

So if you want to take a chance, be my guest. No one is really a bad target if you’re talking third- or fourth-round rookie selections. And at least Evans has some explanation as to why he didn’t have better production in college.

He’s got a better path to relevancy than most Day 3 backs, too.

Evan Hull

RB • Northwestern Wildcats (Indianapolis Colts)

69.6%	+12.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**209**
Statistical Comparables:	**John Kelly** **Elijah McGuire** **Brandon Bolden**

Update: Before this year’s draft, the model’s database had nine running backs with a 20% best-season reception share or better. Christian McCaffrey, James White, and Tony Pollard were all hits, and Rachaad White’s in that group as well. That’s a pretty solid hit rate when you consider only one of those players — CMC — was a high-end pick.

Evan Hull is part of that group now.

Hull is a pass-catching back with good size and athleticism. You can see that the model likes him, but, unfortunately, the landing spot couldn’t be much worse. He fell to Indianapolis at the end of the fifth round, so he’s going to a team with a stud running back and a rookie mobile quarterback. Traditional pocket passers are the ones who usually check down to running backs most, and that’s how Hull would be maximized for fantasy purposes. He’s not getting that.

Had Hull gone somewhere interesting, he’d be a priority in rookie drafts. Instead, he’s yet another back from this class who’s tucked behind a star. Taylor’s at least a free agent next year, so there’s some hope for Hull.

Tyjae Spears

RB • Tulane Green Wave (Tennessee Titans)

78.8%	-4.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'10"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Bilal Powell** **Ronnie Hillman** **Jordan Todman**

Update: The best non-Power Five running back in this year's class got selected in the third round by the Tennessee Titans. He's not Derrick Henry, but Tyjae Spears is also not a bad prospect.

His 2022 season was really spectacular, where he ran the ball 229 times for 1,581 yards and 19 touchdowns. He had 256 yards and a couple of scores through the air, too.

The reason why the Z-Prospect Model doesn't like Spears more is because efficiency isn't what drives the model. Spears had one season with more than 130 carries in college, and he never hit a 10% reception share in a single season. And he did this while playing at Tulane. It's not like he was sharing a backfield with Bijan Robinson.

There's optimism that Spears could become the next Aaron Jones — a smaller-school player who showed off crazy efficiency in college while doing it all in his backfield. The difference is that Jones had far, far more volume at UTEP than Spears saw at Tulane. And Jones' receiving profile was elite.

Tennessee isn't a bad landing spot, though. Derrick Henry is 29 years old, and the team's primary backup, Hassan Haskins, was *definitely* a worse prospect than Spears. The model agrees, too.

Given the lack of touches to his profile and his 201-pound frame, it doesn't seem likely that Spears is going to dominate looks in the NFL. Could he be a really good committee back? Absolutely. That's what we should expect, honestly.

Chase Brown

RB • Illinois Illini (Cincinnati Bengals)

59.1%	-0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**209**
Statistical Comparables:	**Johnathan Franklin** **Lamar Miller** **Jerick McKinnon**

Update: Chase Brown once had high projected draft capital, but things slowly got worse and worse as March and April moved along. He ended up going in Round 5, giving him a pretty mid prospect score. But he got drafted by Cincinnati, and that’s mega intriguing.

Brown has some juice. He ran a 4.43 at the NFL Combine, finishing with the fourth-best Speed Score in this year’s class. His best-season total yards per team play rate is sixth-best in the class, too.

As the pre-draft guide noted, if you were to point to the worst part of Brown’s profile, it would be the fact that he was in college for five years. He’s an older prospect, and that matters at the running back position.

This is probably one of the best Day 3 situations overall, though. Joe Mixon’s had legal troubles this offseason and could be off the team sooner rather than later. And behind Mixon is Trayveon Williams and Chris Evans, two players with far less upside than Brown.

Brown is a good rookie draft target, assuming his cost doesn’t get out of hand.

Kendre Miller

RB • Texas Christian Horned Frogs (New Orleans Saints)

83.5%	-2.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Stevan Ridley** **Alexander Mattison** **Jonathan Williams**

Update: The New Orleans Saints backfield might appear to be crowded — and it currently is — but that doesn’t mean it will be forever. Alvin Kamara not only is facing a possible suspension in 2023, but he’s going to be 28 in July. Jamaal Williams, who they signed this offseason, is already 28.

Kendre Miller, the backfield’s newest member, is one of two backs in this year’s class who has yet to turn 21.

Miller has the right size to be a bell-cow, but his collegiate receiving profile was lacking, which is a huge reason he’s got a negative Draft Capital Delta.

His best-season reception share of 6% isn’t what you look for. No back in the model’s database has had a 16-plus PPR point per game season over their first three years in the league with a reception share lower than 7%. Only three players have gotten over 15 PPR points per game, and one of those three was Josh Jacobs, who had first-round capital.

So the missing receiving production is a problem. Not only do we want to see that work in a profile to help signal talent, but without pass-catching at the next level, it’s hard for running backs to be reliable in fantasy football.

The three-down skill-set may not be obvious, but Miller’s at least great on the ground. In 2022, he avoided tackles at a top-25 rate in college football. His rushing prowess shouldn’t be questioned.

In the end, if you’re buying into Miller — which is a reasonable thing to do — you’re hoping that he can develop into a three-down back. Because he’s not quite there yet. Considering he’s so young, there’s some optimism that he can become one.

Kenny McIntosh

RB • Georgia Bulldogs (Seattle Seahawks)

23.8%	-16.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Prince-Tyson Gulley** **Marion Grice** **Tony Pollard**

So here's the deal. The only NFL Combine athleticism measurable that the Z-Prospect Model cares about at running back is Speed Score, or a weight-adjusted 40-yard dash score.

And it doesn't even care if it's really, really high. Running backs just need to hit a threshold of 90 in order to not get destroyed by the model.

Kenny McIntosh had a Speed Score of 89.6. And it torpedoed his prospect score.

Now, to be fair, that prospect score wasn't great to begin with. McIntosh has an impressive receiving profile, having caught 43 passes last year at Georgia. But, over four years, he tallied just 279 attempts on the ground for the Bulldogs. That resulted in a poor 1.27 best-season total yards per team play rate.

Had McIntosh performed just *slightly* better in the 40, his prospect score would be about 20 percentile spots higher. It made *that* much of a difference. And that may seem unfair. But keep in mind that we've only had one good season from a player in the Z-Prospect Model database with a sub-90 Speed Score. And that was Andre Ellington, who did very little in the league.

Had McIntosh tested better, he would've been inching towards Tony Pollard being a top comparable. (Pollard didn't test as well as he looks in the NFL.) Since things went south, his top-two comparables are pretty ugly.

Israel Abanikanda

RB • Pittsburgh Panthers (New York Jets)

70.8%	+5.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**216**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tyler Gaffney** **Isiah Pacheco** **Bernard Pierce**

Update: There was hope that Izzy Abanikanda would get drafted on Day 2, but he ended up getting snatched in the fifth round instead.

To the Jets.

With Breece Hall there, it’s not a great spot for fantasy production. And it’s unfortunate, because Abanikanda has the goods. He’s a bigger back at 216 pounds, and he had an impressive Speed Score of 109. He also is the youngest running back in this year’s class.

In the prospect database, prior to this year’s draft, just seven running backs had a Speed Score above 105 and a draft-day age under 21. Those backs? Ezekiel Elliott, Joe Mixon, Derrius Guice, Trent Richardson, Todd Gurley, Breece Hall, and Cam Akers.

Abanikanda had a chance to be a massive sleeper in this year’s class. Now, at best, he’s going to slot behind one of the top young talents at the position in the NFL over the next few years. He can still get some work, and there’s a chance he sees more than expected in Year 1 given Hall’s ACL recovery. But it’s a pretty disappointing landing spot when you consider what could’ve been.

DeWayne McBride

RB • Alabama-Birmingham Blazers (Minnesota Vikings)

44.3%	0.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**209**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kapri Bibbs** **Kennedy Brooks** **Cameron Artis-Payne**

Update: One of the better running back landing spots in this year’s draft was Minnesota, and they decided to take a chance with DeWayne McBride in Round 7. It’s hard to imagine that this means Dalvin Cook is a goner, but maybe they’re bullish on the UAB product. Who knows?

What I *do* know is that McBride has one glaring weakness as a prospect, and that’s pass-catching ability. He has one of the worst best-season reception shares in the database at 1.7% after catching just 5 passes in college. It’s safe to say that no running back in Z-Prospect Model history has done anything significant with that low of a reception share.

No running back had that low of a share with a best-season total yards per team play rate above 2.0, though. McBride was ultra-productive on the ground, which is why he’s still rocking a positive Draft Capital Delta.

It’d be shocking if McBride became a running back who consistently saw a double-digit percentage target share in the NFL. That’s not his game. But could he maybe be a Damien Harris-type back for the Vikings? It’s possible.

Chris Rodriguez

RB • Kentucky Wildcats (Washington Commanders)

47.4%	-4.1%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**217**
Statistical Comparables:	**Darius Jackson** **Mike Gillislee** **Larry Rountree**

Chris Rodriguez has the size, but he lacks the explosiveness and the receiving chops that we look for in a fantasy football running back. Pro Football Focus did give him a top-20 rushing grade last season among relevant college football backs, but he had poor yards per route run rates during his five years at Kentucky.

You’re looking at a two-down plodder, more than likely. That’s not the type of player we really want to invest in.

Mohamed Ibrahim

RB • Minnesota Golden Gophers (Undrafted)

17.8%	-18.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'8"**
Weight:	**203**
Statistical Comparables:	**Darrell Henderson** **Devin Singletary** **Anthony McFarland**

Mohamed Ibrahim is just the 28th back in the Z-Prospect Model to measure 5'8'' or shorter with a weight of 200-plus pounds. Among that group, he's one of four with a best-season total yards per team play rate greater than 2.00. The other three? Devin Singletary, Darrell Henderson, and Trayveon Williams.

Ibrahim's production profile could look better on the pass-catching end, but other than that, it's pretty incredible. He accounted for nearly 58% of Minnesota's touchdowns this past year, giving him the best touchdown share in this year's class. His 2.35 total yards per team play rate was second-best, only behind Deuce Vaughn.

Ibrahim is the third player in the model's dataset with a best-season touchdown share of at least 55% to go along with a best-season total yards per team play rate of 2.30 or better.

As you just read, his receiving profile is a problem. So is the fact that he's going to be 25 years old when the NFL's 2023 season begins. That, honestly, is the biggest turn off.

But, on paper, we've seen some success from this kind of profile.

Roschon Johnson

RB • Texas Longhorns (Chicago Bears)

64.5%	-10.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**219**
Statistical Comparables:	**Chris Evans** **Chris Carson** **Bo Scarbrough**

Update: Roschon Johnson’s collegiate production profile sucks because he played with one of the best running back prospects of the decade. Production correlates to NFL success, but in this case, we can give him somewhat of a pass.

There are some quality pieces to Johnson’s profile anyway. He had a passable best-season reception share of 7.5%, and he did that at 219 pounds. We’ve seen some Day 3 hits from bigger-bodied players who had average best-season reception share marks, including Dameon Pierce from last year’s draft.

Johnson was drafted by Chicago with the 115th overall pick, and it’s not a terrible spot for a running back to go. The Bears did sign D’Onta Foreman this offseason to help replace David Montgomery, and Khalil Herbert is there, too. But Foreman’s on a one-year deal, and Herbert’s now on the third year of his rookie contract.

Herbert’s been really underrated on the ground over the last couple of seasons. He was actually fourth in yards after contact per attempt last year. He’s just yet to break out as an every-down back, so Johnson has a shot to prove himself worthy of that role.

Expecting this backfield to not be a committee is probably foolish, though.

Keaton Mitchell

RB • East Carolina Pirates (Undrafted)

18.0%	-18.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'8"**
Weight:	**179**
Statistical Comparables:	**Javian Hawkins** **Trenton Cannon** **Jerrion Ealy**

A team looking for a big-play, change-of-pace back might want to take Keaton Mitchell. He led college football in 10-plus yard runs last season according to Pro Football Focus, and at the NFL Combine, he ran a 4.37 40.

If you're dreaming about a former speedy, smaller-framed ECU running back who ran for 2,000 yards in the NFL, keep dreaming. Chris Johnson was a good bit bigger than Mitchell, had a better collegiate production, and was faster. You're not going to get a huge workload from a 5'8'', 179-pound back. Especially since his receiving work wasn't anything to write home about.

But Mitchell could end up being a depth piece on your dynasty roster for those bye weeks where you need a one-off ceiling play.

Travis Dye

RB • Southern California Trojans (Undrafted)

13.1%	-22.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Akrum Wadley** **Max Borghi** **Elijah McGuire**

Travis Dye doesn’t have good projected draft capital. He probably won’t get drafted at all. But for a player ranked this low, his production profile is kind of intriguing.

Dye played four seasons at Oregon before spending his final campaign in 2022 at Southern Cal. So he’s been around for a minute. His best season was in 2021 as a Duck, where he ran the ball 211 times for 1,271 yards. More importantly, he caught 46 passes that year. His yards per route run rate in 2021 was a top-30 one that we’ve seen among 20-plus target backs over the last two seasons.

In the model, Dye’s 17.7% best-season reception share is fourth-best in this class. And his 1.77 total yards per team play rate could be a lot worse for a potential undrafted player as well.

You probably won’t have to use a rookie pick on Dye, but he’s someone to keep an eye on.

SaRodorick Thompson

RB • Texas Tech Red Raiders (Undrafted)

4.1%	-31.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**207**
Statistical Comparables:	**Prince-Tyson Gulley** **Gary Brightwell** **Michael Cox**

A Speed Score of 87.0 completely drained SaRodorick Thompson's Z-Prospect Model score. He wasn't going to be someone you'd be looking to draft to begin with, but after running a 4.67 at 207 pounds? Nah.

Thompson had a best-season total yards per team play rate of 1.00. And, let me tell you, the players who had a sub-90 Speed Score with that low of a total yards per team play average have been, uh, not great.

You can confidently avoid Thompson in fantasy.

Camerun Peoples

RB • Appalachian State Mountaineers (Undrafted)

11.4%	-24.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**217**
Statistical Comparables:	**Javon Leake** **Matt Jones** **Justin Davis**

Appalachian State has a good football program, but it’s not Alabama. It’s not Georgia or Ohio State.

The fact that Cam Peoples had a sub-3% best-season reception share during his five seasons there is telling. As is his low 1.35 best-season total yards per team play rate.

He’s got good size, but he’ll likely be, at best, a backup early-down runner in the NFL.

Tavion Thomas

RB • Utah Utes (Undrafted)

25.5%	-10.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**237**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kamryn Pettway** **Matthew Tucker** **Synjyn Days**

The biggest dude in this year’s running back class is Tavion Thomas out of Utah. He weighed in at 237 pounds at the NFL Combine, and he ended up running a 4.74 40-yard dash. That may seem slow — and it’s not fast — but his weight-adjusted 40 time was fine.

Thomas wasn’t much of a pass-catcher in college. That’s not uncommon for a back who’s heavier than 230 pounds. In the Z-Prospect Model’s database, the majority of the heavy backs had top-season reception shares in the single digits. But that forced the rest of his production profile to look insanely meh.

Maybe a team falls in love with Thomas’ size? That’s the only thing that’s really working in his favor analytically.

Tiyon Evans

RB • Louisville Cardinals (Undrafted)

19.2%	-16.8%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5'10"**
Weight:	**225**
Statistical Comparables:	**Snoop Conner** **Jonas Gray** **Allen Bradford**

When you're this deep into the prospect model, you're not going to find running backs who were big producers in college. You might find some athletes, though, and that's what we've got in Tiyon Evans.

Evans is a bigger-bodied back with the highest BMI in this year's class. He ended up running a 4.52 40-yard dash at the combine, and at that size, that gave him a pretty good Speed Score of 107.8. Anything over 100 is considered strong.

So, no, the production isn't there at all for Evans. But what if an NFL team can work with his athleticism? That's at least more intriguing than some of the other lower-tiered backs in this class.

Deneric Prince

RB • Tulsa Golden Hurricane (Undrafted)

11.9%	-24.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**216**
Statistical Comparables:	**Keith Marshall** **Christine Michael** **Bryce Brown**

Deneric Prince is the last running back to spotlight, and he’s almost looking like a better version of the aforementioned Tiyon Evans.

Evans is a little bigger, but Prince was the one who beat all running backs in Speed Score this year at the combine. At 216 pounds, he ran a 4.41 40.

Prince profiles similarly to previous athletic busts in fantasy football. Remember Christine Michael? His production profile was horrible, but fantasy managers latched onto him because of his draft capital, size, and athleticism.

Don’t worry: Prince won’t get selected high, so you won’t have any urge to overpay for him in your rookie draft. Unless he falls to the perfect spot, you likely won’t have to draft him at all.

Jaxon Smith-Njigba

WR • Ohio State Buckeyes (Seattle Seahawks)

95.8%	+0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**196**
Statistical Comparables:	**JuJu Smith-Schuster Ja'Marr Chase Garrett Wilson**

Update: Pre-draft, Jaxon Smith-Njigba was projected to go around 12th overall. He fell to 20th, and he landed in a spot — Seattle — where he may struggle to put up top-end production right away.

This is dynasty, though. We're more concerned about his entire career — at least the first three years of his career — versus his rookie season. And while Tyler Lockett and DK Metcalf are there to share the goods, Lockett's going to be 31 years old this season, and he's a potential cut candidate in 2024.

Smith-Njigba ran 89% of his routes from the slot during his monster Sophomore season at Ohio State, and playing alongside DK Metcalf will allow JSN to continue to see a lot of snaps there for the Seahawks. And, in Year 1, we could see him run the *majority* of his routes from that area of the field given Tyler Lockett's still under contract.

It's not the best location for Smith-Njigba imaginable, especially since he'll be competing with more than one high-end wide receiver for targets as a rookie. But it wouldn't be surprising if fantasy managers factor in this destination more than they should. There's an outcome here where, eventually, JSN is seeing more work in this offense than Metcalf. The targets won't be as quality for fantasy purposes, but JSN can still be a PPR machine in a Keenan Allen-type role.

The shift in draft capital moved Smith-Njigba from a 97th percentile prospect to a 95th, 96th percentile one. It would've been nice for him to go a couple of spots higher, but he's still in good shape to be a nice fantasy contributor, most likely during his second or third year in the league.

Jordan Addison

WR • Southern California Trojans (Minnesota Vikings)

94.2%	+0.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**173**
Statistical Comparables:	**Calvin Ridley** **Jahan Dotson** **TY Hilton**

Update: The Jordan Addison-Minnesota Vikings pair is perfect. He's not likely to be an alpha wideout in the NFL, but playing alongside Justin Jefferson means he won't have to be.

Prior to transferring to USC in 2022, Addison spent two years at Pitt (Hail 2 Pitt), and one of those seasons resulted in a Biletnikoff award. That year, he ran 68% of his routes from the slot, per Pro Football Focus, while catching passes from Kenny Pickett. His production then dipped last year as a Trojan, where USC put him in the slot on just 23% of his routes.

We should assume that Minnesota knows all of this, and they won't unintelligently use him as only a perimeter guy. But without Adam Thielen in the mix, Addison should be able to get reps both on the outside and the inside as the team's number-two wide receiver option while seeing easier coverage.

Keep in mind, too, that last year, during Kevin O'Connell's first season with the team, the Vikings ranked fourth in neutral script pass rate. So Addison will be the second option on what'll likely be a pass-heavy team.

When looking at 2023 projections, it's clear that Addison could perform best among any wide receiver in this class. It doesn't mean he's the top wideout from the group, but it does bode well for his Year 1 to Year 2 appreciation in the dynasty market. It's almost like a beefed up Jahan Dotson situation from last year.

If you're looking for a pretty safe bet at wide receiver, Addison's your guy.

Quentin Johnston

WR • Texas Christian Horned Frogs (Los Angeles Chargers)

93.4%	-1.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**208**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tee Higgins** **Alec Pierce** **Breshad Perriman**

Update: There's a lot of volatility to Quentin Johnston's analytical profile, but at least the landing spot is secure. He'll join two aged wideouts in Keenan Allen (will be 31 during the 2023 season) and Mike Williams (29), opening a path to opportunity in this Justin Herbert-led offense.

The biggest issue with Johnston is that he's a physically gifted wide receiver who tends to play a little small. In 2022, per Pro Football Focus, Johnston ranked in the 27th percentile in contested catch rate. He was able to stretch the field at TCU, at least, with high average depth of targets (aDOT) during all three collegiate seasons. And he has a rare blend of high aDOTs and strong yards after the catch numbers.

His best-season yards per team pass attempt of 2.35 is merely average, but had he stayed healthy during his Freshman and Sophomore seasons, he had a chance to hit the 2.00 mark within that metric during all three collegiate seasons. That consistency is something we don't often see, and it's definitely not something we've seen from previous first-round busts out of Texas Christian in Josh Doctson and Jalen Reagor. He looks like a better prospect than they were.

Drafting Johnston depends on your risk tolerance. You could certainly argue that, with this draft capital and with this landing spot, he has just as high of a fantasy football ceiling as any other wideout in this draft. The bust potential is just higher than someone like Jaxon Smith-Njigba or Jordan Addison. That's clear when you peep his comparables.

Josh Downs

WR • North Carolina Tar Heels (Indianapolis Colts)

86.7%	+8.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**171**
Statistical Comparables:	**Elijah Moore** **Tyler Lockett** **Wan’Dale Robinson**

Update: The Colts got a steal with Josh Downs. At least, that’s what the Z-Prospect Model thinks.

Downs has the highest best-season yards per team pass attempt rate in this class at 3.52. And now that he got Round 3 draft capital, he joins Tyler Lockett as the only third-round wide receiver since 2011 to have a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above 3.50 and a Breakout Age earlier than 20 years old.

Tyler Lockett is one of Josh Downs’ comps.

Lockett’s been able to show off his ability and be more than a slot guy in the NFL, and we’re going to need to see that from Downs, since he ran 83%, 95%, and 87% of his routes from the slot at North Carolina.

Even if he can’t be more than a slot player, though, he can still be productive.

Hopefully.

Indianapolis isn’t the best destination in the world for Downs. They drafted Anthony Richardson, so Downs is on Richardson’s developmental timeline. He didn’t fall to a spot with some secure quarterback who’s in desperate need of a slot receiver.

But we’ve got to trust the process here. Downs’ prospect score is strong, and he should be able to start as the Colts’ main slot wideout immediately. He’s just got to beat Isaiah McKenzie.

Jalin Hyatt

WR • Tennessee Volunteers (New York Giants)

83.9%	+4.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**176**
Statistical Comparables:	**Nelson Agholor** **Jameson Williams** **Calvin Ridley**

Update: Jalin Hyatt fell a lot further in the draft than most expected, but now that he’s a third-rounder, it’s easier to be bullish on him versus expectation.

Hyatt’s analytical profile is kind of all over the place. He saw very little production during his first two seasons at Tennessee, and then he blew up in 2022, winning the Biletnikoff Award. That gave him a later-ish Breakout Age, but the best-season production is fantastic.

Hyatt’s more than likely going to be asked to play the perimeter in the NFL in order to stretch defenses vertically with his speed. Considering the Giants — his new team — have about seven slot receivers currently rostered, that seems even more likely.

The problem is that Hyatt played over 87% of his snaps from the slot last season. It was a weird role in the Tennessee offense, but it was one that allowed Hyatt to get free pretty easily and generate a ton of production.

This isn’t to say that he’s bad. It’s more so to say that there are a lot of question marks. That’s why it’s easier to buy into him now as opposed to him being an early second-round pick.

And if you want some optimism, among wide receivers drafted between Picks 65 and 100 (roughly Round 3) from 2011 to 2020 who had a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of 3.00 or greater (Hyatt’s part of this subset), 26.7% were able to post a 15-plus PPR point per game season during one of their first three campaigns in the league. The alternative group — guys with a yards per team pass attempt rate below 3.00 — was at 11.8%.

Because the model’s comparables loosely factor in draft capital, the players listed for Hyatt are better than they probably should be. But he still has potential to be a fantasy contributor in an offense that lacks high-end weapons.

Zay Flowers

WR • Boston College Golden Eagles (Baltimore Ravens)

92.9%	-1.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**182**
Statistical Comparables:	**Phillip Dorsett** **Randall Cobb** **Markus Wheaton**

Update: Zay Flowers’ comps are rough, and it’s because he’s a non-early-declare wide receiver who had good-not-great collegiate production. But when you dig a little deeper, you start to uncover things that point to him being a really good player.

Flowers, despite his size, largely played a perimeter role in college. His slot rate in 2022 was just 33%, and it was 26% the year prior. So we have evidence that he can play all over the formation despite his size.

His top-season yards per team pass attempt of 2.45 isn’t special, but he hit a 2.25 rate in each of his final three seasons at Boston College. Among Power Five wideouts in this year’s class, he’s the only one to have done that.

Flowers is now paired up with Lamar Jackson in Baltimore. Historically, that hasn’t been a great match for a wide receiver — the Ravens have had a pass rate above 50% just once over their last four seasons.

But there’s some hope that the team becomes a little more pass-friendly under offensive coordinator Todd Monken, who’s never led an NFL offense below a 56% pass rate. And Baltimore’s made moves this offseason to suggest they want to throw the ball a little more.

The competition is there in Baltimore, to be clear. Rashod Bateman hasn’t been able to stay healthy, but he was studly in the yards per route run department during his limited time last year. Mark Andrews is *always* going to command a high target share. And maybe Odell Beckham has a little left in the tank.

On the flip side, what if Bateman can’t stay healthy? What if Beckham is washed? All of a sudden, Zay Flowers becomes the number-two option in this new-look offense. That’s why he’s still a fine enough rookie pick. The talent is there.

Kayshon Boutte

WR • Louisiana State Tigers (New England Patriots)

70.7%	+18.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**195**
Statistical Comparables:	**Amon-Ra St. Brown** **Antonio Callaway** **Kenny Stills**

Update: This may be a little galaxy brained, but Kayshon Boutte going to New England might be the best thing possible from a fantasy perspective. His rookie draft cost has been slipping since his awful showing at the combine, and now he’s a Day 3 pick, going to a team that’s struggled mightily with wide receiver evaluation in the past.

You think fantasy football managers are going to want to buy into this?

If Boutte becomes a last-round dart throw, he’s the perfect target. Some have questioned his motivation, but now he’s playing for Bill Belichick, a coach who’s not going to put up with lazy route running.

And, I mean, objectively, Boutte’s profile isn’t horrible. He broke out as a Freshman with a 1.75 yards per team pass attempt rate, battled through injury as a Sophomore, and he just couldn’t get back to form as a Junior. His Breakout Age and early-declare status is a fairly rare combination for a Day 3 pick. Since 2011, just eight early-declare wide receivers — Boutte included — drafted after Pick 100 had a Breakout Age before 19 and a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above 1.70. Two of those players were Stefon Diggs and Amon-Ra St. Brown.

There’s a ton — a *ton* — of red flags surrounding Boutte. You shouldn’t be giving up a top-two round rookie pick to acquire him in any format.

With that being said, he’s someone to keep an eye on.

Parker Washington

WR • Penn State Nittany Lions (Jacksonville Jaguars)

67.2%	+14.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Amari Rodgers** **Parris Campbell** **Dwayne Harris**

Update: Parker Washington’s prospect score makes him look better than he probably is. He’s built more like a running back than a wide receiver, and he largely played the slot during his three seasons at Penn State. Even after Jahan Dotson left for the NFL last year, Washington ran over 71% of his routes from the slot.

Washington’s production was never elite, but it was good enough to give him a strong Breakout Age. That, combined with his early-declare status, is why his prospect score looks as good as it does.

There’s very little chance he’s a high-volume player on Jacksonville in 2023 with Christian Kirk, Calvin Ridley, and Zay Jones in the mix. Kirk is the player that Washington should be most concerned about, since he ran over 75% of his routes from the slot last season. His contract goes through 2025, but the Jags seem to have a potential out in 2024. That just doesn’t seem probable.

All this means is that Washington is a stash more than anything. You’re hoping the Jacksonville wide receiver room gets a shakeup after 2023, but even then, we can’t bank on Washington being the dude they’d want to utilize in the slot consistently.

Rashee Rice

WR • Southern Methodist Mustangs (Kansas City Chiefs)

78.1%	-6.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Cecil Shorts** **Mohamed Sanu** **Geremy Davis**

Update: You have to imagine Rashee Rice got a lot pricier in rookie drafts when he was selected by the Chiefs in the second round.

The Z-Prospect Model isn't *super* excited.

Now, to be fair, the model doesn't have some Patrick Mahomes input. But we've learned to not ignore the prospect himself just because he's playing with the greatest young quarterback of all time. Right?

Right?

Rice has good size, and his stat score is a top-10 one in this year's class. The problem is that he didn't have the best Breakout Age, he's already 23 years old, and he didn't face the toughest competition in college. Even though he played four seasons in the American Athletic Conference, he hit a 2.00 yards per team pass attempt rate just once.

He's not a bad prospect, but he's not someone with incredible odds to hit, either.

Jayden Reed

WR • Michigan State Spartans (Green Bay Packers)

83.4%	-3.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**187**
Statistical Comparables:	**Cam Phillips** **Stefon Diggs** **Tylan Wallace**

Update: My favorite wide receiver sleeper in this year’s draft is a sleeper no more. With the 50th overall pick, the Green Bay Packers selected Jayden Reed out of Michigan State.

If you recall, Reed played his Freshman season at Western Michigan before transferring to Michigan State. He broke out as a Freshman, outperforming future second-rounder Dee Eskridge, who was a Junior.

Skyy Moore got to Western Michigan the following year — Reed had transferred at this point — and ended up with a worse Freshman season yards per team pass attempt rate compared to Reed’s.

It’s fitting that Reed was drafted in the second round, too.

Reed played all over the field when he got to Michigan State, and he got work as a returner as well. His production profile doesn’t look *elite* in the Z-Prospect Model, per se, but the production is definitely there.

And that Breakout Age is clutch, too. From 2011 to 2020, 51 wideouts were drafted in the Pick 32 to 100 range with a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above 2.50. Of those 51, just 8 broke out in college before turning 19 years old. So 43 of them had Breakout Ages of 19 or older.

Among the group with elite Breakout Ages, 5 (62.5%) were able to give fantasy managers a season of 14 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three years in the league. The alternate group made that happen at a 23.2% rate.

Reed shouldn’t have trouble seeing some action as a rookie for the Packers. And while Christian Watson and Romeo Doubs are good players — especially Watson — there’s a non-zero chance Reed eventually is the main target hog in this offense.

Marvin Mims

WR • Oklahoma Sooners (Denver Broncos)

82.2%	+0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**183**
Statistical Comparables:	**KJ Hamler** **Isaiah Ford** **Jerry Jeudy**

Update: I’ll say it again: From 2011 to 2020, 51 wideouts were drafted in the Pick 32 to 100 range with a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above 2.50. Of those 51, just 8 broke out in college before turning 19 years old. So 43 of them had Breakout Ages of 19 or older.

Among the group with elite Breakout Ages, 5 (62.5%) were able to give fantasy managers a season of 14 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three years in the league. The alternate group made that happen at a 23.2% rate.

Marvin Mims was drafted in the second round by the Denver Broncos, and his breakout happened before he turned 19.

Mims is an easy prospect to like. He’s a big play waiting to happen after seeing average depth of targets of 17.0, 17.6, and 15.4 during his three collegiate seasons. He did that while running his routes all over the field — despite his size, he wasn’t locked into the slot.

If there’s something negative about Mims’ profile to point out, it’s that even though he technically broke out early, he wasn’t overly productive until his final season at Oklahoma. He was fortunate to get to the right thresholds in order to produce that Freshman breakout. But it happened, and he’s an early-declare wideout in a class that doesn’t have a ton of them.

Funny enough, two of Mims’ three comparables are current Denver Broncos. The difference is that he’s the only one who was drafted by this Sean Payton regime. Even if we can’t currently see a super clear path to relevancy, in dynasty, you want to target good players in your rookie draft. And Mims is a good player.

Nathaniel Dell

WR • Houston Cougars (Houston Texans)

76.8% Z-Prospect Score	**-3.9%** Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**165**
Statistical Comparables:	**Scotty Miller** **Jaelon Darden** **Wan’Dale Robinson**

Update: Nathaniel “Tank” Dell goes from Houston to…Houston. The Texans snagged the small wideout in the third round, and Dell officially became just the fourth sub-170-pound wide receiver drafted in the top-100 since 2011. The other three? Marquise Brown (166 pounds), Devonta Smith (166), and Tutu Atwell (153).

The obvious difference between Dell and players like Marquise Brown and Devonta Smith is draft capital. And that’s what makes him a very difficult prospect to project.

On the plus side, Dell has the second-best stat score within this draft class, trailing only Josh Downs. On the minus side, he didn’t have a super strong Breakout Age, and he’s entering the NFL at 23-and-a-half years old. He played at Houston for three seasons, but he started his college journey at Alabama A&M and a community college.

It’s hard to imagine Dell as a high-volume perimeter receiver. He ran more than half of his routes from the slot during his two highly productive seasons at Houston, and while he *can* separate — especially deep — his size will likely force him to the slot a good bit.

He could play that role for the Texans right away, at least.

Dell’s a solid player, but he may lack the upside we want from a fantasy contributor. It’s very possible he ends up being a better real-life player than fantasy one.

Cedric Tillman

WR • Tennessee Volunteers (Cleveland Browns)

75.6%	-3.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’3”**
Weight:	**213**
Statistical Comparables:	**Cobi Hamilton** **Kevin White** **Nick Toon**

Update: The Z-Prospect Model isn’t the biggest Cedric Tillman fan. He’s got great size at 6’3’’, 213 pounds, but his Breakout Age is one of the worst in the class among players who broke out, and he’s entering the league at 23 years old.

Tillman had an impressive Junior season with Tennessee, and he hit a 2.89 yards per team pass attempt rate while playing alongside two NFLers in Velus Jones and Jalin Hyatt. Had he come out after that season, the model would’ve looked at him more favorably.

The Browns were the team who grabbed Tillman in the third, and they likely did so knowing that Donovan Peoples-Jones is set to become a free agent in 2024. With DPJ, Amari Cooper, and Elijah Moore already on the roster, there’s some chance Tillman doesn’t get a ton of run during his rookie season. But if he learns the system and the Browns feel good about his development, then they may feel as though Peoples-Jones is expendable.

That’s sort of the problem for Tillman. It’d be one thing to wait it out with a raw prospect who was 21 years old, but he’s an older player entering the league. By the time he gets going — if it happens — he could be 25 or 26. That’s a harder thing to bank on in dynasty.

Of course, he could always surprise and just beat out a player like Peoples-Jones this year. It just doesn’t seem like the most likely outcome.

Trey Palmer

WR • Nebraska Cornhuskers (Tampa Bay Buccaneers)

59.5%	+8.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**192**
Statistical Comparables:	**AJ Jenkins** **Jared Abbrederis** **Malcolm Mitchell**

There’s only one wide receiver in this year’s draft class with a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of 3.00 or better to go along with a best-season touchdown share mark above 50%. And his name is Trey Palmer.

Historically, drafted wide receivers who’ve hit those marks have done pretty well. There’ve been 21 of them since 2011, and 10 of those 21 were able to get to a double-digit PPR points per game season in one of their first three in the league.

The problem with Palmer’s numbers is that he did very little across the first three years of his college career. He was at LSU during that time, and he only caught 41 passes as a Tiger. To be fair to Palmer, though, those LSU teams did have some great wide receiving talent.

Palmer made the most of his opportunity in 2022, at least, but the late-career production gave him a poor Breakout Age, which is lowering his overall score in the model. As is the fact that he’s not projected to be a Day 2 pick at the moment.

Palmer’s capable of creating big plays down the field with his speed, but you have to wonder if there’s going to be more that he can offer for fantasy managers at the next level.

Xavier Hutchinson

WR • Iowa State Cyclones (Houston Texans)

50.3%	+2.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**203**
Statistical Comparables:	**DeVante Parker** **Denzel Mims** **Devin Street**

Biletnikoff Award finalists are typically going to have strong production profiles. And Xavier Hutchinson, a finalist last season, caught 107 passes for 1,171 yards and 6 scores in 2022.

Those numbers look good on paper, but they’re not *as* impressive as you’d think. Hutchinson is fine in the Z-Prospect Model on the production end, but his yards per team pass attempt and touchdown share marks were ordinary. That’s because his average depth of target rates throughout college were below 10 yards, per Pro Football Focus. He was seeing a ton of easy looks in the Iowa State offense, getting targeted closer to the line of scrimmage. There are definite question marks around his ability to separate down the field.

It’s good that he was targeted at a high rate, but this is why receptions per game works with yards per team pass attempt. Hutchinson was good, but he wasn’t great.

His collegiate journey wasn’t super clean, either. He started off at Blinn College — a place we’ve definitely all heard of before — before transferring to Iowa State. He then played three years as a Cyclone and was productive each year.

Hutchinson enters the NFL Draft as an older player — he’ll be almost 23 — but his Breakout Age was OK. So while the age concerns are valid, they’re probably easy to overstate. The bigger deal is draft capital, since there’s a chance he falls outside the top-100.

The optimistic side to Hutchinson is that he can play anywhere, and he’s seemingly gotten better each year. There are worse darts to throw in rookie drafts.

AT Perry

WR • Wake Forest Demon Deacons (New Orleans Saints)

53.5%	+3.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**198**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kris Durham** **Derek Moye** **Alonzo Russell**

AT Perry is 6’4’’, but it doesn’t really matter.

Age-adjusted production is what’s key, and Perry doesn’t exactly have it. His best seasons in yards per team pass attempt and touchdown share are below average, and he broke out late in college. He redshirted his Freshman year, and it took him three seasons at Wake Forest to post substantial production. He enters the draft well over 23 years of age, too, having turned 23 in October of 2022.

In the Z-Prospect Model database, there’ve been 18 wide receivers with the following criteria: non-early declare status, a Breakout Age above 21, a best-season yards per team pass attempt below 2.5, and a height of 6’4’’ or taller.

Are those random parameters? Sort of. We’re really just looking at lengthy dudes who didn’t have great age-adjusted production.

Of those 18, Chase Claypool was the only one who gave fantasy managers 10-plus PPR points per game in one of his first three seasons. And not only did Claypool’s production profile look better than Perry’s does, but he also had 40 pounds on him.

This type of profile — AT Perry’s profile — is volatile. Could the height translate? Of course. Is it something you should bank on? Probably not. At least not in the early rounds of your rookie drafts.

Rakim Jarrett

WR • Maryland Terrapins (Undrafted)

34.9%	0.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**192**
Statistical Comparables:	**Antonio Callaway** **Kenny Lawler** **Cody Core**

There are almost 100 wide receivers in the Z-Prospect Model with a best-season receptions per game rate below 5.0, a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate below 2.0, and a best-season touchdown share below 25%.

Only one of them scored more than 16 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons in the league. That was Tyreek Hill. And only four – add Terry McLaurin, Hunter Renfrow, and Jaylen Waddle to the list – scored more than 12.5.

For Rakim Jarrett to be a solid fantasy option through 2025, he’ll kind of need to be an outlier. His stat score is in the bottom-15 in this year’s draft class, and there really have only been three or four hits within the model from a player with such a low score.

If you want to look at things optimistically – and the model actually doesn’t mind Jarrett versus where he’s projected to be drafted because of this – Jarrett does have an OK Breakout Age. And he’s an early-declare receiver. And he was a five-star recruit coming out of high school. *And* he wasn’t the only Maryland wide receiver at the combine this year, so there was at least decent competition for him in college.

Nevertheless, we’re inching towards praying-hands-emoji territory of the prospect guide.

Dontayvion Wicks

WR• Virginia Cavaliers (Green Bay Packers)

52.6%	-7.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**203**
Statistical Comparables:	**Mike Woods** **Kevin Austin** **Corey Fuller**

Dontayvion Wicks missed his Sophomore year with an injury sustained before the season started, but he bounced back in a big way the following year, posting the ninth-highest yards per route run rate in college football among 50-plus target wide receivers.

That 2021 campaign was by far his best, but within the Z-Prospect Model, it’s not looking special: All three of his production metrics clocked in below average.

It’s pretty rare for a player to become something in fantasy football with below-average marks across the board. Just six players in the model’s database have gotten to 15-plus PPR points per game during their first three years in the league while having under-the-norm marks in receptions per game, yards per team pass attempt, and touchdown share.

Two of the players who beat the odds were Martavis Bryant and DK Metcalf. They both tested as athletic freaks, something we didn’t get from Wicks at the combine. So it’s not looking likely that Wicks is going to be an every-week starter in your fantasy lineup on Sundays.

Charlie Jones

WR • Purdue Boilermakers (Cincinnati Bengals)

53.9%	-11.3%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**175**
Statistical Comparables:	**Clyde Gates** **Titus Young** **Quez Watkins**

Update: It’s easy to poke fun at Charlie Jones’ profile. He started his collegiate career all the way back in 2018 with Buffalo before transferring to Iowa. Because of the NCAA’s transfer rules, he sat out the 2019 season before getting a shot with the Hawkeyes in 2020. He spent two years there without much production before moving to Purdue, where he played his final season.

And that final season was pretty good. He caught 110 passes for 1,361 yards, resulting in a yards per team pass attempt of 2.33.

With all that movement, Jones is unsurprisingly one of the oldest wide receivers in this class at 24 and a half. In the Z-Prospect Model’s database, the only moderate hit from a player who entered the league at 24 is John Brown.

That doesn’t mean Jones is an avoid in rookie drafts. Chances are, your leaguemates aren’t going to care much for a wideout who’s been able to legally purchase alcohol for almost four years. He’s not going to be costly. And there are still pieces to his profile to like. He can line up all over the field, and he has better speed than most would assume.

The Bengals — the team that drafted him — have both Tyler Boyd and Tee Higgins sitting on the final years of their respective contracts. There could be openings in a Joe Burrow-led offense in 2024. So stashing Jones with a last-round pick isn’t a bad idea. It’s not like other late-round darts have high odds to work out anyway.

Tyler Scott

WR • Cincinnati Bearcats (Chicago Bears)

65.1%	+1.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**177**
Statistical Comparables:	**John Metchie** **Darius Johnson** **KJ Hamler**

Update: It was odd to see Tyler Scott get picked 33 spots after his Cincinnati teammate, Tre Tucker, but the Bears got a good one at the tail-end of the fourth round of this year’s draft.

Scott had a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of only 2.17, but he hit a max-season touchdown share of almost 41%, one of the better marks in the class. He’s got great speed to stretch the field and profiles best, given his size, as a vertical slot threat in the NFL.

This is similar to a nugget mentioned with Kayshon Boutte, but since 2011, we’ve seen just eight other early-declare wide receivers get selected between Picks 100 and 150 (Scott was the 133rd overall pick) with a best-season touchdown share above 35%. Two of those eight receivers were Stefon Diggs and Amon-Ra St. Brown.

Darnell Mooney and Chase Claypool are both set to be free agents in 2024, so there could be an opening in that offense next season. And maybe Scott works his way into some playing time this year, too. He’s a pretty good later-round option in rookie drafts.

Jadon Haselwood

WR • Arkansas Razorbacks (Undrafted)

11.7%	-23.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Greg Childs** **Javon McKinley** **Vince Mayle**

Jadon Haselwood is a former five-star recruit with good size, but there’s not much working in his favor analytically.

All three of his production metrics in the Z-Prospect Model came in below average, and his sub-2.00 receiving yards per team pass attempt and sub-20% touchdown share put him in pretty weak company. Just 4% of wide receivers in the model’s database have given us a WR2 season or better within the first three years of their NFL career with those marks.

Haselwood’s only productive season came as a Senior at Arkansas, which followed three years at Oklahoma. During that season, he ran 81% of his routes from the slot. The fact that we didn’t see him win as much on the perimeter could limit his upside at the next level, too.

Andrei Iosivas

WR • Princeton Tigers (Cincinnati Bengals)

45.0%	-2.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**205**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tyre Brady** **Jazz Ferguson** **Kenny Golladay**

Update: As you probably read with Charlie Jones, the Cincinnati Bengals are going to be facing some decisions at wide receiver after the 2023 season. Both Tyler Boyd and Tee Higgins are free agents, so they likely loaded up on a couple of late-round wideouts in this draft to see if they could get lucky.

Andrei Iosivas was one of them. He's a smaller-school player with a great production profile, but that's to be expected when you're an NFL-caliber wideout playing at Princeton. He mostly played on the perimeter there, and at 6'3'', 205 pounds, the Bengals are probably seeing him more in a role opposite of Ja'Marr Chase, too. That is, if he can prove himself worthy of getting any playing time.

I'm not sure that's going to happen. Small-school players don't often hit at wide receiver, and Iosivas is an older prospect, entering the league at 23-and-a-half.

If you've got a deep enough rookie draft, you can stash him and see what happens. There's no need to prioritize him late.

Jonathan Mingo

WR • Mississippi Rebels (Carolina Panthers)

84.2%	-5.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**220**
Statistical Comparables:	**Gary Jennings** **Jaylen Smith** **Juron Criner**

Update: When this prospect guide initially launched, Jonathan Mingo was projected to go 170th overall in this year's draft. And then he went 39th to the Carolina Panthers.

The comparables you see are generated with draft capital in mind — somewhat, at least — so Mingo didn't get the benefit of having a pretty pre-draft profile. Post-draft? We should be paying a whole lot more attention.

Mingo's analytical profile is nothing special. He's not an early-declare pass-catcher, and his top season in yards per team pass attempt was just 2.22. That was by far his best year within the statistic.

Part of the reason for that, however, was because he wasn't able to stay healthy until his Senior season. He played with some decent wide receiver talent in Elijah Moore, Braylon Sanders, and Dontario Drummond, too.

When you match all of that with poor draft capital, it's a tough sell. But a second-round selection? Now we're talking.

The biggest reason Mingo rose in the draft — more than likely — is his size. He's 220 pounds, giving him the fourth-highest BMI in this class. And it's a class that doesn't have a lot of big-bodied players.

Reception Perception's Matt Harmon thinks Mingo, despite maxing out at a 35% slot rate in college, could end up using his strong route-running as a big slot in the NFL. Carolina doesn't have any locked-in long-term receiver options, so it's nice that Mingo can work with them to find a role that's best suited for his skill-set.

Mingo isn't someone the fantasy community likes given his poor analytical profile. But that's why we use draft capital. Even with a bad Draft Capital Delta and poor production, he could be a value in your rookie drafts this year.

Dontay Demus

WR • Maryland Terrapins (Undrafted)

20.9%	-14.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’3”**
Weight:	**212**
Statistical Comparables:	**Emmanuel Butler** **Denzel Mims** **Malachi Dupre**

The Z-Prospect Model is far from flawless, and one of the issues that it’s very rarely run into over the last couple of seasons has to do with the dreaded COVID year.

Back in 2020, most teams just played a handful of games. That leads to smaller sample sizes, and with smaller sample sizes comes the potential for whackier numbers.

That’s what we’re getting with Dontay Demus. His collegiate profile is objectively average compared to other NFL-hungry wide receivers. He played at Maryland for five years, and he failed to reach 650 yards in any of those seasons. It's just that, in 2020, Demus saw a large chunk of Maryland’s offense…during a five-game season. So his numbers look better than they probably should.

This is the context that’s always necessary to have, and why these profiles are helpful. Demus looks OK in the model, and he’s got some decent analytical qualities, like a good Breakout Age and solid size. But he may be *slightly* overvalued by the model because of that COVID season.

Demario Douglas

WR • Liberty Flames (New England Patriots)

42.9%	-2.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**179**
Statistical Comparables:	**Calvin Austin** **Ryan Switzer** **Jakeem Grant**

The last time we saw a wide receiver from Liberty get NFL Draft love was in 2020 with Antonio Gandy-Golden. He was selected in the fourth round by Washington, and he proceeded to catch a grand total of one pass in the NFL before retiring in 2022.

Smaller-school wide receivers are always a risk. It could be that Gandy-Golden just didn’t care much for football — a totally rational thing to feel — but Power Five wide receivers are generally better bets than the pass-catchers from smaller programs.

That’s one of the things that makes Demario Douglas a tough player to bet on for fantasy production. He also had worse marks across the board compared to Gandy-Golden, and he’s a little wide receiver, standing at 5’8’’.

Since 2011, there’ve been 21 wideouts in the Z-Prospect Model database who entered the league below 5’9’’. Of those 21, 16 had a best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate below 3.0, which is a category Douglas falls into.

Take a guess at how many of those 16 wide receivers have given us a WR2 season in PPR points per game?

Zilch.

He’s got good athleticism, but Douglas is probably someone who will work better in real football than fantasy football.

Ronnie Bell

WR • Michigan Wolverines (San Francisco 49ers)

29.3%	-6.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**191**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tavarres King** **Charleston Rambo** **Danny Coale**

We're seeing a lot of older prospects this year, and it's probably the result of the pandemic shifting eligibility. Ronnie Bell is one of those players — he turned 23 back in January after completing his final season at Michigan as a fifth-year Senior.

So, yeah, his age-adjusted production isn't great. His top season in college easily came in 2022, where he caught 62 passes for 889 yards, leading to a 2.40 receiving yards per team pass attempt rate. He consistently didn't do well as a touchdown scorer in college, failing to get higher than a 16.7% touchdown share in any season. Most successful NFL wide receivers far exceeded that tally.

Bell ended up reaching a 2.0 yards per route run rate — per Pro Football Focus — during every season at Michigan, which is a pretty impressive feat. That's not even something Jaxon Smith-Njigba can say.

But, overall, Bell looks like a fairly ordinary prospect. You can see that by looking at his statistical comparables.

Mitchell Tinsley

WR • Penn State Nittany Lions (Undrafted)

9.5%	-25.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**199**
Statistical Comparables:	**Shaquelle Evans** **Cornell Powell** **Michael Campanaro**

Mitchell Tinsley's football journey is all over the place. He kicked things off by playing two years at a community college before transferring to Western Kentucky. He then spent two years *there* before finally moving to Penn State, the spot where he played his Senior season.

Tinsley put up some big numbers at Western Kentucky — he had a 1,400-yard season in 2021 — but those Hilltopper teams were really pass-heavy. In 2021, they ranked second in pass rate across college football. In turn, Tinsley's best-season yards per team pass attempt figure isn't nearly as good as you might think, sitting at 2.01.

Because of all the team hopping, Tinsley is entering the league as a 23-year-old who's passed his half birthday. Only one wide receiver has entered the NFL at 23-and-a-half or older with a sub-2.5 best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt and hit 10-plus PPR points in one of his first three years in the league. That was Terry McLaurin.

Mitchell Tinsley is not Terry McLaurin.

CJ Johnson

WR • East Carolina Pirates (Undrafted)

14.1%	-20.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**224**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kalija Lipscomb** **Robert Davis** **Marquez Callaway**

We didn’t see CJ Johnson participate at the NFL Combine, but we got his measurements. And he’s got great size for the position, coming in as one of the five wideouts in this class with a BMI above 28.

Johnson played four years at East Carolina, and he was productive in each season. You could easily argue — I’d say it’s just factual — that his Freshman season was the second-best year of his ECU career, which isn’t normal. But it gave him one of the better Breakout Ages in this year’s class.

And that gives us some signal. Since 2011, among players drafted after Pick 100 with a Breakout Age below 19.5, about 13% of them were able to score 10-plus PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons in the league. When a player had a Breakout Age *later* than 19.5, that number dropped down to 5.2%.

If Johnson goes undrafted, the dream is over. But, at the moment, he looks like the right kind of dart to throw at the end of rookie drafts.

Bryce Ford-Wheaton

WR • West Virginia Mountaineers (Undrafted)

8.2%	-26.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'4"**
Weight:	**221**
Statistical Comparables:	**Dezmon Patmon** **Brice Butler** **Miles Boykin**

If you had to describe Bryce Ford-Wheaton with an emoji, it'd be the rocket one. Without a doubt. Because not only did he have some jets on at the combine, but he's going to shoot up draft boards thanks to his performance there.

Ford-Wheaton is 6'4'' and 221 pounds, and he ran a 4.38 40-yard dash. That gave him a height-adjusted Speed Score — so a height- and weight-adjusted 40 time — that was by far the best in this year's class.

It's also one of the best we've seen over the last decade from a wide receiver. We saw Chase Claypool and DK Metcalf get there in recent memory, and Julio Jones did years ago, too. But there aren't many wide receivers hitting that sort of 40 at that height and weight.

Now, like I said at the top, athleticism measurables aren't factored into the Z-Prospect Model at wide receiver, and it's probably because it's already captured in draft capital. So Bryce Ford-Wheaton's fast 40 doesn't *directly* matter, but it could *indirectly* make an impact in April.

And Ford-Wheaton's going to need as much of a boost in draft capital as he can get. His college production wasn't all that great, with a best-season yards per team pass attempt of 1.59.

Physically, he's like DK Metcalf. The difference is that Metcalf was more productive — he knew how to use his athleticism on a football field — so it's tough to think of Metcalf as even a higher-end comp for Ford-Wheaton.

Instead, your top comps for Ford-Wheaton are the uber-athletes who just couldn't convert at the NFL level.

Puka Nacua

WR • Brigham Young Cougars (Los Angeles Rams)

46.5%	-7.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Alec Pierce** **J'Mon Moore** **DaMarkus Lodge**

Update: Among all 50-plus target wide receivers last season, Puka Nacua ranked second in yards per route run. He didn't score very well in best-season yards per team pass attempt (2.03), but that's partially due to the fact that he only played 9 of 13 games. His pro-rated yards per team pass attempt was 2.31, which is passable.

Nacua started his college career with Washington before transferring to Brigham Young as a Junior in 2021. BYU used him in all sorts of ways that Washington didn't, and he ended up tallying 39 carries in two seasons as a Cougar. Those numbers aren't factored into the prospect model, but they do signal talent. The team was trying to get the ball in his hands.

Nacua ended up falling to the Rams in Round 5, and LA could use the wide receiver help. Cooper Kupp is the only locked-in piece in that offense, and Van Jefferson is set to be a free agent next season.

The Z-Prospect Model doesn't have high hopes for Nacua, but as you just read, there are reasons to feel OK about his outlook. And unlike most Day 3 picks this year, he could see production right away. Sometimes that's all you need from a late-round selection.

Malik Heath

WR • Mississippi Rebels (Undrafted)

9.2%	-25.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**213**
Statistical Comparables:	**Javon Wims** **Travis Fulgham** **Mark Harrison**

Like many pass-catchers in the 2023 draft class, Malik Heath bounced around before exiting school to chase an NFL dream. He started things off by playing at a community college for a couple of years, and then he found a spot on Mississippi State’s team in 2020. After two more years there, he transferred to Ole Miss where he played his Senior season, catching 60 passes for 971 yards and 5 scores.

Heath’s 2.51 best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt isn’t all that bad, and his yards per route run rate last season was fine, too. And at 6’2’’, 213 pounds, he has almost ideal size.

It’s just going to be hard for the Z-Prospect Model to like an older player who isn’t projected to go very high in the NFL Draft. He didn’t do enough at the NFL Combine to really boost his stock, either.

Elijah Higgins

WR • Stanford Cardinal (Miami Dolphins)

40.7%	-8.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**235**
Statistical Comparables:	**Vince Mayle** **Quincy Enunwa** **Greg Little**

Update: Elijah Higgins is the biggest "wide receiver" in this year's class. The reason wide receiver is in quotes – I'm making bunny ears with my fingers here – is because there's a very real chance he moves to tight end.

The Miami Dolphins were the team that took him in the sixth round of the draft. The Dolphins currently have Durham Smythe as their top tight end. They could use more pass-catching ability there after losing Mike Gesicki during free agency.

As we know, Miami wants to win with speed. They've got Tyreek Hill and Jaylen Waddle, and they drafted Devon Achane, who ran a 4.32 40-yard dash. Higgins, at 235 pounds, ran a 4.54 40, giving him a really strong height-adjusted Speed Score.

Higgins is a very interesting name to keep in mind late in tight end premium rookie drafts.

Justin Shorter

WR • Florida Gators (Buffalo Bills)

40.5%	-20.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**229**
Statistical Comparables:	**Juwan Johnson** **Rodney Smith** **Dylan Cantrell**

Update: The Bills added size when they drafted Justin Shorter in the fifth round of the draft.

They didn’t add a receiver with a good analytical profile.

Shorter is 6’4’’ and nearly 230 pounds, but he somehow walked away from his five years in college with 8 total touchdowns and a best-season touchdown share of only 11.5%. His top season in yards per team pass attempt was 1.58, giving him a bottom-10 mark in this class. He was a five-star recruit back in the day — people once thought Shorter was going to be the next big thing — but it just never came to fruition in college.

It’s tough to totally fade pass-catchers who are associated with such good offenses, but don’t let the landing spot get in the way of the player. This doesn’t look like a Gabe Davis situation. Shorter’s profile is worse.

Jake Bobo

WR • UCLA Bruins (Undrafted)

0.2%	-34.7%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**206**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jaleel Scott** **Stephen Guidry** **Jehu Chesson**

Jake Bobo is going to be 25 years old in August. You’ll be shocked to hear this, but of all the players who were drafted at 24-and-a-half years old or older, none have come close to being good fantasy producers.

Will Bobo break the mold? Highly doubtful. He’s got good length at 6’4’’, and he didn’t have a bad super Senior season in 2022. His receiving yards per team pass attempt was below 2.00, though, and he failed to reach a 25% touchdown share.

It would be pretty shocking if Bobo not only got good draft capital, but was then productive in fantasy football.

Jalen Cropper

WR • Fresno State Bulldogs (Undrafted)

15.4%	-19.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**172**
Statistical Comparables:	**JJ Nelson** **Jovon Durante** **Whop Philyor**

The main reason Jalen Cropper has such a poor pre-draft prospect score is because no one seems to like him. His projected draft capital is undrafted at the moment, so if he hears his name in April, expect a boost. Because his numbers really aren’t that bad.

He’s smaller in size, and that forced him into the slot a whole lot at Fresno State. What’s interesting, though, is that he went from running 91% and 95% of his routes from the slot as a Sophomore and Junior, respectively, to just a 17% rate as a Senior. And the production didn’t dip — he had arguably his most productive season last year.

Don’t get me wrong, a 5’10’’, 172-pound wide receiver probably isn’t going to be pushing cornerbacks around on the perimeter in the NFL. It just shows us that he’s a versatile athlete. That showed up at the combine, too, where he ran a 4.40 40.

Cropper has a stat score above zero in the Z-Prospect Model, which isn’t easy to find in a player ranked this low. Hopefully he gets OK draft capital, because he looks like a sneaky-decent player.

Matt Landers

WR • Arkansas Razorbacks (Undrafted)

14.0%	-20.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**200**
Statistical Comparables:	**Marquez Valdes-Scantling** **Tommy Streeter** **Marcell Ateman**

Matt Landers showed off his speed at the NFL Combine, running his 40 in 4.37 seconds. Only Trey Palmer and Derius Davis were faster at wide receiver, and Landers has more length than both of those wide receivers do, making his time more impressive.

The good news mostly stops there. Landers did have a productive Senior season where he finished with a 2.52 yards per team pass attempt, but it was a journey to get there. He started his collegiate career at Georgia before landing in Toledo as a Junior. After a fairly mediocre season there, he moved over to Arkansas where he caught 47 balls for 901 yards and 8 scores during his only year as a Razorback.

So, uh, he’s pretty old. Once again, we’ve got a near 24-year-old wideout in this year’s class, and that’s a bad sign for future fantasy performance.

Maybe a team will fall in love with the speed?

Jason Brownlee

WR • Southern Mississippi Golden Eagles (Undrafted)

Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta
2.7%	-32.2%

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**198**
Statistical Comparables:	**Ty Fryfogle** **Tamorrion Terry** **Samori Toure**

Jason Brownlee spent three years at Southern Mississippi after a stint at East Mississippi Community College. Shocker: We've got another older prospect in this class.

His best-season marks are pretty good, but that's to be expected at a school like Souther Mississippi. He had a best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate of 2.58, which was 11th-best in the class, and his top-season touchdown share of 57.14% was tied for the absolute best in the class.

As a standalone figure, having that high of a touchdown share doesn't really matter. Not a single wide receiver with a 57% best-season touchdown share and bad draft capital (past Pick 200) has become anything in fantasy football over the last decade.

Brownlee, who turned 24 in January, isn't someone you should be overly interested in right now.

Tre Tucker

WR • Cincinnati Bearcats (Las Vegas Raiders)

51.0%	-21.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**182**
Statistical Comparables:	**Ray-Ray McCloud** **Marquise Goodwin** **Isaiah Burse**

Update: Surprisingly, Tre Tucker was the first Cincinnati Bearcat wide receiver to get selected in the draft. Tyler Scott’s the one with the stronger production metrics across the board, but the Raiders — go figure — went ahead of took Tucker with the 100th pick of the draft.

As you can see from his score, he’s very unlikely to be a fantasy football difference-maker. His top season in yards per team pass attempt was just 1.62, a 20th percentile mark in this class. He’s undersized, too. Tucker does have speed, which is why he was drafted in the third round in the first place, but that’s not enough to buy into him being a fantasy producer.

This feels like the Danny Gray pick from last year all over again. You can let someone else take Tucker in your rookie draft, assuming there’s some opportunity cost involved in doing so.

Grant DuBose

WR • Charlotte 49ers (Green Bay Packers)

38.3%	+2.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Austin Pettis** **Matt Hazel** **Ventell Bryant**

There may not be a bigger underdog story in this class than what you're getting with Grant DuBose. No larger program wanted him on their football team out of high school, and he ended up playing his Freshman season at Miles College in Alabama. He then took a year off due to COVID-19, and in 2021, he tried out for UNC-Charlotte. And the rest is history.

DuBose's numbers weren't spectacular within the context of Charlotte football. He had a negative stat score in the model, and each one of his production metrics were a little bit below average. Players from smaller programs generally need monster numbers if they have any hope of being productive in the NFL.

He's not projected to go high in the draft, either.

But he's a fun player to root for.

Kearis Jackson

WR • Georgia Bulldogs (Undrafted)

1.8%	-33.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**196**
Statistical Comparables:	**Reggie Roberson** **Steven Mitchell** **Slade Bolden**

Kearis Jackson went to a stellar program in Georgia, but he failed to produce NFL-caliber numbers there. His best season came as a Sophomore back in 2020 where he ran nearly 91% of his routes from the slot. He played from that part of the field often at Georgia, but even with softer coverage, he was only able to capture a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of 1.68.

Jackson is an older prospect after spending five years as a Bulldog, and he has the seventh-worst stat score in this year’s class. It would be quite a surprise to see him as a fantasy-relevant piece at some point over the next few seasons.

Michael Jefferson

WR • Louisiana-Lafayette Ragin' Cajuns (Undrafted)

7.2%	-27.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'4"**
Weight:	**199**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jamal Custis** **Brice Butler** **Mekale McKay**

None of the smaller-program wide receivers with best-season yards per team pass attempt rates under 2.00 in the Z-Prospect Model have become anything in fantasy football. Well, except for Tyreek Hill, but Hill technically did play one year at Oklahoma State.

Michael Jefferson played at Louisiana-Lafayette for a couple of years after transferring from Alabama State. Despite going up against inferior talent, he has a bottom-15 stat score among wideouts in this year's class. He's also going to be almost 23-and-a-half years old by the time the draft rolls around.

There's a chance Jefferson doesn't hear his name called during this year's NFL Draft. Even if he does, there's a very low chance that he'll be worthy of rostering in any fantasy format.

Michael Wilson

WR • Stanford Cardinal (Arizona Cardinals)

58.8%	-14.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**213**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jalen Camp** **Chris Moore** **Toney Clemons**

Update: There are Michael Wilson truthers out there, but I — and the model — am not one of them.

Wilson has the right frame for an NFL wide receiver, but he struggled mightily to stay healthy during his time at Stanford. That resulted in a best-season yards per team play rate of 1.51, one of the lower rates in the class. He also didn’t test exceptionally well as an athlete, making the Day 2 selection by Arizona that much more surprising.

Wilson did *barely* break out as a Sophomore, so he has that going for him. And maybe he can finally stay uninjured as he enters the NFL. It’s just that even if he had stayed healthy in college, it doesn’t seem like he would’ve been some big producer. His prorated numbers in yards per team pass attempt still show up below 2.00, a number hit by 60% of this wide receiver class.

The Cardinals are going through some changes, so there’s opportunity for him to show up and get some work. It just doesn’t seem wise to be optimistic about Wilson as a prospect.

Jacob Copeland

WR • Maryland Terrapins (Undrafted)

1.0%	-33.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jon'Vea Johnson** **Darrell Stewart** **Kaelin Clay**

Of the three Maryland wide receivers in this year’s class, Jacob Copeland has the worst best-season receptions per game, yards per team pass attempt, and touchdown share rates. He’s also the oldest of the trio, which doesn’t help things.

He did test as the most athletic at the combine after running a 4.42, but that doesn’t matter nearly as much as the production side of things. Maybe that explosiveness ends up translating, but that’s not what we generally see.

With poor numbers across the board, you shouldn’t have high expectations for Copeland.

Antoine Green

WR • North Carolina Tar Heels (Detroit Lions)

33.1%	-10.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**199**
Statistical Comparables:	**Van Jefferson** **Damion Ratley** **Kenbrell Thompkins**

A lot of the lower-tiered guys in this year’s class look the same on paper. They have fine enough size, but they stuck around school for a while — likely due to the COVID season — and never were able to put together an ultra-productive campaign.

Like, Antoine Green had a best-season 1.61 yards per team pass attempt rate despite playing five years at North Carolina. Maybe that number would’ve looked a little better had he been healthier in 2022, but, at best, he wasn’t reaching the 2.00 mark.

With Josh Downs playing the slot in Carolina, Green took on a perimeter role. And he got vertical. His average depth of target rates over his final two seasons at UNC were 19.0 and 18.1, and he was 11th among relevant wide receivers this past year across college football in percentage of targets that were 20-plus yards down the field.

It just would’ve been nice to see Green with a *little* more speed at the combine. He ran a 4.47 40-yard dash, which is strong, but if he’s going to play that stretch-the-field role, he’ll need even more speed to separate at the next level.

Malik Knowles

WR • Kansas State Wildcats (Undrafted)

4.5%	-30.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**196**
Statistical Comparables:	**Daesean Hamilton** **Emanuel Hall** **Seth Williams**

Malik Knowles spent five years at Kansas State. He redshirted as a Freshman, and then he went down the traditional path of playing all four years.

He didn't do a whole lot of special things there. His top season in yards per team pass attempt was 1.86, and he was just shy of a best-season touchdown share of 30%. Those numbers are better than some of the other lower-end wideouts in the class, but they're still not elevating him to a spot where he's bound to be a great fantasy producer.

Knowles is a perimeter wide receiver who had some experience as a kick returner for the Wildcats. That's something you can hold onto to boost him a little bit subjectively, but without the projected draft capital, he's unlikely to be anything more than a WR4 or WR5 for fantasy purposes.

Joseph Ngata

WR • Clemson Tigers (Undrafted)

10.1%	-24.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’3”**
Weight:	**217**
Statistical Comparables:	**Racey McMath** **Evan Spencer** **Austin Mack**

Exiting high school, Joseph Ngata was a five-star recruit. There were high hopes.

So, uh, about that.

Ngata has the worst stat score in this year’s draft class. Some of that is injury-driven, but he spent four years at Clemson and failed to hit a 10% touchdown share in a single season. He’s the 12th wide receiver in the Z-Prospect Model with a best-season touchdown share below that 10% mark.

It gets worse. His top-season in yards per team pass attempt was just 1.10. That’s a bottom-25 number.

He has the physical tools, but the route running and ability to separate just haven’t been there for him. It’s tough to feel good about him, even with the exciting post-high school hype.

Jalen Wayne

WR • South Alabama Jaguars (Undrafted)

0.3%	-34.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**Toney Clemons** **Rashawn Scott** **Javon McKinley**

If there's a type of profile to avoid at wide receiver, it's Jalen Wayne's.

He went to a small school, something you don't want from a wide receiver for fantasy purposes. Despite facing easier opponents, each of his Z-Prospect Model production marks were below average. He also played *six* collegiate seasons. And, because of that, he'll be 24 years old around draft time.

Wayne was obliterated production-wise at South Alabama by teammate Jalen Tolbert. Remember Tolbert? The guy who couldn't find the field for the wide receiver-needy Cowboys in 2022? Yeah. He was a whole lot better than Wayne.

It would be the surprise of the decade — remember, the model dates back to 2011 — if Wayne became a fantasy football staple.

Derius Davis

WR • Texas Christian Horned Frogs (Los Angeles Chargers)

38.9%	-27.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**165**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jeff Thomas** **Jakeem Grant** **Kashif Moore**

Update: Like the pre-draft prospect guide said, Derius Davis was bound to see a bump in draft capital after running the second-fastest wide receiver 40-yard dash at this year’s combine.

Did anyone expect a fourth-round selection?

Davis joins TCU teammate Quentin Johnston on the Chargers, giving Justin Herbert a speedy, gadgety pass-catcher. Unfortunately, there’s probably not much happening here from a fantasy perspective. Davis is undersized and had a bottom-tiered production profile within this year’s class. That’s despite the fact that he played five years at Texas Christian.

We could see some electric plays from Davis in this Chargers offense, but asking him to be a high-volume player is a little much.

Jaray Jenkins

WR • Louisiana State Tigers (Undrafted)

6.4%	-28.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Chris Lacy** **Darius White** **Binjimen Victor**

We’ve seen some studs come out of LSU over the last decade, but Jaray Jenkins doesn’t have the same type of backbone that some of those players had. His stat score is third-worst in this year’s draft class, his career high in yards per route run is just 1.78, and he lacks higher-end athleticism. The size is there, but there’s nothing that stands out. At all.

We did see Russell Gage come out of LSU and become a reasonable fantasy asset, and he, like Jenkins, had a poor production score. But that’s really not something I’d want to lean on, even with a last-round rookie pick.

Jalen Brooks

WR • South Carolina Gamecocks (Dallas Cowboys)

25.2%	-12.4%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**James Wright** **Slade Bolden** **Kenbrell Thompkins**

Athleticism isn't everything at wide receiver, but it's never a good sign when a player runs the slowest 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine. It's even worse when that same player has a best-season touchdown share below 5%, having scored two total touchdowns across four collegiate seasons.

That's what we've got out of Jalen Brooks. And that top-season touchdown share is worrisome. Only five other wide receivers in the Z-Prospect Model have had one that low and, predictably, none of them have done anything in fantasy football at the next level.

You can confidently avoid Brooks in your rookie drafts.

The Year 2 Model

Overview

We learn more about players with time. A rookie entering the NFL is a whole lot more unpredictable than a six-year veteran. You're looking at a player who's never stepped foot on an NFL field versus one who's potentially played close to 100 games in the league.

Naturally, after a player gets through his rookie season, we understand more about his game. Garrett Wilson got to Jets camp last summer as a stud prospect, but there wasn't some guarantee that he'd be a star in the NFL. It turned out that he is, and now we can adjust accordingly.

Not every player and situation is as clear-cut as that, though. There are second-year players across the league with giant question marks.

That's where the Year 2 Model comes into play.

> The goal of the Year 2 Model is to be much better at predicting his second- and third-year production than a player's rookie-season points per game average.

The Year 2 Model — both at running back and wide receiver — incorporates a player's prospect score, some rookie-season production inputs, and his rookie-season points per game average to get a Year 2 score. That's the gist of it.

Everything in the Year 2 Model ties back to a player's max-season PPR points per game during his second or third season. So if a player scored

16 and 19 points per game during his second and third season, respectively, the model only cares about that 19 points per game mark.

As you'd guess, the Year 2 Model is a lot better at predicting a player's best points per game season in Year 2 or Year 3 than his rookie-season points per game average alone.

To me, this all is logical.

> **If a player came from nowhere — if a guy wasn't supposed to be good, but he balled out during his rookie year — then there's more risk with that player than if an early-round pick did the exact same thing.**

There's more risk with Dameon Pierce or Isiah Pacheco going into 2023 than there is with Kenneth Walker.

The Year 2 Model can help us out when higher draft selections underperform, too. Is Skyy Moore, a second-round pick last year, doomed? What about Alec Pierce?

Similar to the Z-Prospect Model, there are easy-to-understand probability charts for the Year 2 Model.

Wide Receiver (Best PPR Season; Years 2-3)

Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	0%	100%	100%	87%	70%	52%	22%
90-95	13%	87%	78%	48%	22%	9%	4%
85-90	40%	60%	36%	24%	8%	4%	4%
80-85	58%	42%	19%	15%	8%	4%	0%
75-80	83%	17%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
70-75	88%	12%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	96%	4%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	100%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%

The Year 2 Model is straight up more predictive than the Z-Prospect Model. That shouldn't be much of a surprise considering we're working with actual NFL data, and we've gotten some sample of a player as a professional.

The wide receiver table above clearly shows that. Of the wide receivers since 2011 with three-plus seasons in the league who ranked in the 95th to 100th percentile in Year 2 score, every single one gave us a PPR points per game season of 12 or more in either Year 2 or Year 3. A shocking 52% of them hit 18 or more PPR points, a typical top-five wide receiver finish.

> Historically, a wide receiver in the elite percentile group has had about 50-50 odds to give you a top-5 season in PPR points per game during either Year 2 or Year 3.

As you move from group to group, the hit rates predictably change. Wide receivers in the 70th to 75th percentile tier almost always fail to give you a double-digit PPR season in Year 2 or Year 3. Under that 70th percentile mark? Good luck.

So people are aware, the wide receiver Year 2 Model changed a bit from last year. New inputs were inserted, and the model became even more predictive.

Unfortunately, it means that last year's results aren't *totally* the same. Nothing dramatically shifted, but it sure would've been nice to have the changes last season. Because, for example, Elijah Moore's Year 2 score dropped a couple of percentage points with the new additions to the model. He doesn't look *as* appetizing.

That could've saved me a lot of headaches as an analyst!

Nevertheless, the model's accuracy is even better, and that's a good thing.

The model looks pretty good at running back, too, but things aren't as clean.

Running Back (Best PPR Season; Years 2-3)

Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	12%	88%	76%	76%	65%	53%	47%
90-95	11%	89%	61%	50%	33%	17%	6%
85-90	69%	31%	25%	6%	6%	0%	0%
80-85	57%	43%	14%	14%	0%	0%	0%
75-80	63%	38%	38%	25%	13%	13%	6%
70-75	53%	47%	21%	11%	5%	0%	0%
65-70	65%	35%	24%	6%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	80%	20%	13%	13%	13%	7%	7%

Running back is a tougher position to project than wide receiver. If a coach decides to split his backfield, then that's going to ruin the fantasy upside for a running back. You don't really run into that issue at wide receiver since so many are on the field at once.

With all that being said, it's pretty clear that the 95th to 100th percentile tier at running back is elite. It's where the truly high-ceiling seasons are coming from. Nearly half of the players from that tier have given you a high-end RB1 season since 2011.

The next tier isn't so bad, either, but you're not getting as much upside.

Overall, betting on a 90th percentile or better running back seems like a good call. Below that, there's a lot more risk.

Journey Comparables

Elijah Mitchell was *great* during his rookie season. He sort of came out of nowhere — he was a sixth-round pick in the NFL Draft — and then scored 15 PPR points per game during his first year in the league.

Kyle shanahan is an animal.

After that rookie season, fantasy managers were wondering whether Mitchell was a buy or sell in dynasty. He clearly had an outlier season — not many Day 3 picks do what he did as a rookie — but because his season was anything but ordinary, did that mean his career would be, too?

Enter Journey Comparables.

You've probably already read about statistical comparables with the Z-Prospect Model profiles earlier. Journey Comparables are a little different. Rather than looking at a player's attributes as he enters the league, Journey Comparables inspect a player's Z-Prospect Model score along with his Year 2 Model score. It then looks at players in history who have gone through a similar path — a similar journey — from before Year 1 to before Year 2.

Journey Comparables don't deal with play style, height, weight, or any other qualities. It's simply a look at players in history who entered the league as a similarly graded prospect who then went into their second season with a comparable Year 2 Model score as well.

Elijah Mitchell was an odd case, but it wasn't as unique as you might think. He entered the NFL as a 55th percentile prospect, and after his rookie season, he had a Year 2 Model score in the 87th percentile.

No player had gone through that identical jump in score, but there were a few who were close: Zac Stacy, Andre Ellington, and James Robinson. Those comps led yours truly down a path to thinking Mitchell was more than a sell than a buy.

History often repeats itself. In fantasy football, too.

Selling Mitchell

The Year 2 Model pegged Mitchell as a sub-90th percentile player last season. It's almost impossible for late-round running backs to hit the 90th percentile in the Year 2 Model because it's so rare for them to sustain success.

2023 Year 2 Model Profiles

Overview

If you were one of the fortunate ones who drafted Isiah Pacheco in your dynasty rookie draft last year, is now the time to trade him away? Is George Pickens about to become a foundational dynasty asset? Are there any players from last year's draft class who are totally flying under the radar?

These Year 2 Model profiles can help answer those questions.

Over the final section of this guide, you'll read about all relevant wide receivers and running backs from last year's draft class.

> You'll see where the Year 2 Model has them ranked, and you'll get insight on how to manage each player moving forward.

Let's reshape those dynasty rosters.

Key Terms

Z-Prospect Score: The score — often in percentile form — given to an incoming rookie in the Z-Prospect Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the Z-Prospect Overview section of this guide.

B2S: The Z-Prospect Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The percentile difference between a player's Z-Prospect score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. Anything under 0 means the player was overdrafted, and anything over 0 means the player was underdrafted.

Journey Comparables: Players in history who have had similar Z-Prospect Model and Year 2 Model scores.

Expected Max PPR PPG Season: The estimated outcome in best-season PPR points per game in Year 2 or Year 3 for a particular player. This is simply a median, so the number is likely smaller than expected.

Breece Hall

RB • New York Jets

96.9%	97.1%
Z-Prospect Score	Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**16.4**
Journey Comparables:	**Dalvin Cook Giovani Bernard Najee Harris**

Breece Hall might be better than you think. During his rookie campaign that was cut short by a torn ACL, Hall led NFL running backs in yards after contact per attempt, and he saw the largest difference in his yards per carry versus his running back teammate's yards per carry in the league.

The only reason his Year 2 Model score isn't higher is because he had an incomplete season. But the fact that it's still well over the 95th percentile mark shows you that he's legitimate.

Hall should be considered one of the best running backs in dynasty, even with the ACL tear. His 16.3 expected max PPR point per game season isn't *that* stellar, but, as you saw earlier, half of the running backs in this percentile group go on to have a high-end RB1 season in either Year 2 or Year 3. Maybe it won't happen right away for Hall, but he's the best bet out of anyone from last year's class.

Kenneth Walker

RB • Seattle Seahawks

93.2%	94.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**13.9**
Journey Comparables:	**Nick Chubb** **TJ Yeldon** **Javonte Williams**

At first, it seemed strange that Kenneth Walker saw a modest jump in percentile ranking from his Z-Prospect Model score to his Year 2 Model one. But when you dig into his rookie campaign, it all makes sense.

Walker's big red flag entering the NFL was his pass-catching profile. His best-season reception share was lacking, which allowed yours truly to put him in a tier below the aforementioned Breece Hall. That was the big difference between the two.

Walker's rookie season didn't exactly show us that his college receiving profile should've been ignored. Remember, poor pass-catching numbers in college don't necessarily mean a player will fail to catch any passes in the NFL. It's just a signal for talent.

But a poor receiving profile at the collegiate level rarely leads to a great receiving profile in the pros. And during Walker's rookie campaign, once he took over as starter for Seattle, he had just a 7.5% target share per game rate in the Seahawks offense.

His rushing numbers were — and I hate to say this — pretty overrated, too. Among all 100-plus attempt backs in 2022, Walker ranked worst in percentage of carries that went 0 or fewer yards. He was also last in success rate, per numberFire's expected points model.

He should have a productive career, but it's hard to see an alpha ceiling for Walker. The fact that Nick Chubb keeps popping up as a comparable — he was a statistical comp for Walker as a prospect — points to the fact that Walker could end up being a better real football running back than fantasy one.

Dameon Pierce

RB • Houston Texans

68.0% Z-Prospect Score	88.8% Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**11.2**
Journey Comparables:	**Jordan Howard** **Alfred Morris** **Jamaal Williams**

Dameon Pierce is probably the toughest Year 2 Model evaluation this year at running back. He didn't score exceptionally well in the Z-Prospect Model thanks to being part of a backfield split in college, and his draft capital wasn't special, either.

There were underlying metrics that favored Pierce as a prospect, though. He had the best Pro Football Focus grade of any collegiate running back in 2021, and all of his per-attempt numbers were exceptional.

That really showed during his first year in the league. Pierce, on a team without much competition, ended his year with an 86.4% running back rush share per game. Not only was that by far the best share from a rookie back this past year, but it was the fifth-best that we've seen from a first-year runner since 2011.

I wish we could say that that's telling about his future, but the players ranked ahead of him on that list are James Robinson, Alfred Morris, Elijah Mitchell, and Kareem Hunt. We're talking about good-not-great backs here.

Pierce's Journey Comparables consist of players who were solid pros after sort of being afterthoughts during the NFL Draft. The odds that he becomes a top-10 dynasty running back are pretty slim, but it's not like he's priced that way.

You could go either way with Pierce right now. It just depends on how your leaguemates view him.

Rachaad White

RB • Tampa Bay Buccaneers

85.4%	88.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**10.9**
Journey Comparables:	**David Montgomery** **Tre Mason** **Jerick McKinnon**

Rachaad White wasn't a stellar runner in 2022, ranking towards the bottom of the league in percentage of carries that went more than zero and more than two yards. He was getting stuffed often. He did, however, finish with an almost identical success rate as Leonard Fournette, so he wasn't so bad when given situational context.

The promising part of White's game was and still is his receiving chops. His best-season reception share of 20.9% in college was a big reason the Z-Prospect Model loved him, and in 2022, White averaged a target share per game rate of 7.7% in a part-time role. He finished more games with a target share above 10% last year than Kenneth Walker did. And Walker was a full-time guy for most of the season.

White seems to be properly valued by the dynasty market. Your hopes shouldn't be sky high, but a player in the 87th percentile has had about 60% odds of scoring double-digit PPR points in his second or third year in the league. There's some worry that the Buccaneers add competition for him this offseason, though.

Tyler Allgeier

RB • Atlanta Falcons

70.1%	82.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**9.3**
Journey Comparables:	**Marlon Mack** **Matt Jones** **Kenneth Gainwell**

Tyler Allgeier had one of the highest Draft Capital Deltas in the 2022 running back class. He was a Day 3 pick, so expectations weren't high, but he was able to get over the 70th percentile mark. That's not easy to do with that type of draft capital.

And he showed up for the Falcons. Per Pro Football Focus data, only Breece Hall, Rhamondre Stevenson, Tony Pollard, and Khalil Herbert had a higher yards after contact per attempt last year than Allgeier. He became just the 17th rookie running back since 2011 to hit the 1,000-yard mark, too.

Unfortunately, he had just a 4.3% target share last year. It's not super common to see a running back with a sub-5% target share in Year 1 go on to be a consistent RB1 or RB2 in fantasy football. We've seen it before — and one player who's done it was one of the Allgeier comps last offseason in James Conner — but it's not a normal occurrence.

As is usually the case, the market appears to be accounting for this. Given his Year 2 Model percentile score is in the 82nd percentile, he's probably more of a hold than a sell. Just keep in mind that we almost never see players from this tier go on to be RB1s in fantasy during Year 2 and Year 3 of their careers.

James Cook

RB • Buffalo Bills

83.1%	81.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**9.4**
Journey Comparables:	**Terrance West** **Zack Moss** **CJ Prosise**

The Bills have been chasing a pass-catching running back over the last few years, and they seemed to have their guy when they selected James Cook in Round 2 last year.

And then they didn't use him as that player at all in 2022.

Cook finished the season with a target share below 6%. He was pretty effective on the ground, however, finishing with a 47.3% success rate, a number that was 4 percentage points higher than Devin Singletary's. Cook also had a yards per carry rate that was 1.2 yards better than his running back teammates, a number that ranked ninth-best among 66 running backs with 50 or more carries last year.

He still needs to get his target share up, though. And it's not impossible for that to happen. Over the last 11 seasons, we've had 17 running backs fail to get to a 6% target share in Year 1 who then got to a 13% target share or better in future seasons. Those aren't great odds, but they're there.

Looking at his Journey Comparables, it's hard to be ultra bullish on Cook. Once you get out of that 90th percentile range in the model, you start to get some iffy output.

Brian Robinson

RB • Washington Commanders

72.1%	79.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**8.7**
Journey Comparables:	**Samaje Perine** **Marlon Mack** **Devonta Freeman**

You could definitely have worse Journey Comparables than Samaje Perine, Marlon Mack, and Devonta Freeman, no?

Robinson is sort of like a Tyler Allgeier-lite. He was effective enough on the ground, and he finished the year with over 200 carries. We only get two or three rookie running backs hitting that mark per season.

His receiving work? That was about as good as the Game of Thrones series finale.

Robinson had a 3.6% target share per game rate in 2022. Here's a list of the rookie backs since 2011 with 200-plus carries and a sub-5% target share per game average: Brian Robinson, Tyler Allgeier, Alfred Morris, Vick Ballard, and Sony Michel.

Like so many of these backs around the 80th percentile in the Z-Prospect Model, Robinson's future is up in the air because he just wasn't used as a receiver in Year 1. He, like Tyler Allgeier and James Cook, isn't really someone I'd actively look to buy this offseason.

Isiah Pacheco

RB • Kansas City Chiefs

48.2%	70.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Daryl Richardson** **Ty Johnson** **Chris Carson**

A Late-Round Prospect Guide favorite from last year, Isiah Pacheco has seen his stock skyrocket since being drafted. He had one of the best Draft Capital Deltas in the class a year ago, but his Z-Prospect score still wasn't all that high given he was selected in the seventh round.

That's undoubtedly bringing his Year 2 Model score down. As is the fact that he wasn't used much as a receiver this past year — he only tallied 14 total targets in the regular season. That usage changed a bit in the playoffs, but it's still a concern.

Pacheco's valuation in dynasty is going to be all over the place. So let me just hit you with a bit of history.

In the Z-Prospect Model, we've got over 120 running backs with a prospect score in the 30th to 60th percentile. That's where Pacheco was last year. Of those backs, just two have had a season of 15 or more PPR points per game across their first three years in the league. One was Myles Gaskin, and the other was Chris Carson, who's one of Pacheco's Journey Comparables.

It's understandable if you'd want to just ride the Pacheco wave. As someone with him in a ton — almost all — of my dynasty leagues, I'll be doing that in spots. But if someone is willing to overspend after a strong playoff performance, you should be open to it, as hard as that is for me to admit.

Jaylen Warren

RB • Pittsburgh Steelers

32.0% Z-Prospect Score	63.8% Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**5.8**
Journey Comparables:	**Justin Jackson** **Bryce Brown** **Alfred Blue**

Jaylen Warren was a quintessential handcuff during his rookie campaign. Truthfully, the Z-Prospect Model didn't think he had it in him: We rarely see backs with a score under the 35th percentile do anything in fantasy.

But Warren had a really solid season. He bested teammate Najee Harris in yards after contact per attempt, and Pro Football Focus gave Warren the top receiving grade in 2022 out of the runners in the Steelers backfield.

It's tough to imagine a world where Warren thrives outside of a Najee Harris injury, at least in the short term. And, remember, the Year 2 Model is looking at that short-term outlook. That's likely why his top Journey Comparable is Justin Jackson — a player who was fantasy relevant at times, but usually due to injury to a starter.

Zonovan Knight

RB • New York Jets

25.3%	62.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**5.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Josh Adams** **Salvon Ahmed** **Bryce Brown**

It's a little startling to see Bam Knight's Year 2 Model score so close to Isiah Pacheco's. It's only five percentiles away. Consider this, though: Knight only played seven games in 2022, and he was a weekly RB2 or better in three — about 43% — of them. That's technically a better rate of finishing as an RB2-plus than Pacheco's 41%.

The two are clearly and obviously valued differently in dynasty. And that's because Knight is dealing with Breece Hall in a more volatile offense. Pacheco soared during the playoffs, has Patrick Mahomes and Andy Reid, and isn't dealing with anything substantial on his depth chart.

Pacheco *should* be valued much higher than Knight.

Knight's Journey Comparables aren't thrilling, and his score places him in a tier that lacks serious upside. He'll likely be, at best, a good handcuff in fantasy.

Chris Olave

WR • New Orleans Saints

97.9%	99.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**19.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Odell Beckham** **AJ Green** **CeeDee Lamb**

The near-98th percentile score that was spit out for Chris Olave by the Z-Prospect Model last year was a little controversial.

Until he balled out during his rookie season.

I'm still not sure people realize how good Olave was in 2022. There've been over 110 rookie wide receiver seasons since 2011 where the wideout saw 50 or more targets. So this isn't even *all* rookies, but ones who were good enough to capture 50 targets.

Chris Olave's rookie season yards per route run rate ranked fifth-best among that group, behind only Odell Beckham, AJ Brown, Justin Jefferson, and Ja'Marr Chase. His *targets* per route run rate was fourth-best.

Garrett Wilson is rightfully getting a lot of love by fantasy managers and the media. He's a stud. Olave, though, is just as studly. Even more so than Wilson, per the model.

Only eight other wide receivers since 2011 have gotten to the 98th percentile in the Year 2 Model while playing three years in the league. The lowest PPR points per game output in Year 2 or 3 by any of those players came from Amari Cooper, where he maxed out at 14.4 points. That's still a WR2 season in a 12-team league.

Chris Olave is legit. He's probably even more legit than you realize.

Drake London

WR • Atlanta Falcons

98.4%	**98.4%**
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**18.2**
Journey Comparables:	**Julio Jones** **Mike Evans** **Justin Blackmon**

Last year's top receiver in the Z-Prospect Model was Drake London. Clearly, he's not at the top anymore.

That doesn't mean he's in bad shape. London's still sitting above the 98th percentile after a pretty underrated rookie campaign. His fantasy output was capped by a 1960s style offense that threw the ball at the fourth-lowest rate of the decade. London's rookie season actually saw him with a far better yards per route run average than Garrett Wilson, and his targets per route run rate was the third-best we've seen from any rookie pass-catcher since 2011.

Most importantly, London saw a whole lot of volume. The only rookie wideout with a higher target share per game rate dating back to the 2011 season was Odell Beckham. That resulted in a yards per team pass attempt of 2.09. The only rookie wideouts during this timeframe with a better number there were Justin Jefferson, Ja'Marr Chase, AJ Brown, and Odell Beckham.

If anyone in your dynasty league is worried about London because of his situation, you should be jumping all over the opportunity to acquire him. All of his underlying metrics are fantastic, and the Year 2 Model thinks he's got a great shot to be a WR1 in fantasy football.

Garrett Wilson

WR • New York Jets

97.4%	97.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**17.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Jaylen Waddle** **CeeDee Lamb** **AJ Green**

It may be surprising to see Garrett Wilson ranked below both Chris Olave and Drake London in Year 2 Model. He's listed ahead of both in dynasty rankings and will get selected first in startups, and he's coming off an Offensive Rookie of the Year season.

So, uh, what's happening here?

Well, first off, I wouldn't be so concerned about the small gap in score. A near-98th percentile rating is still extremely good, and it places Wilson in the same tier as the other two wideouts. Let's not take this further than it needs to go.

But for as good as Wilson was in Year 1, Olave and London had some peripheral numbers that just looked better. Their yards per route run rates were stronger. Their offensive shares were better. And, for London, his starting point – his Z-Prospect score – was higher.

The fact of the matter is, the three of them – Chris Olave, Drake London, and Garrett Wilson – appear to be studs. Players in this upgraded Year 2 Model who fall in the 95th to 100th percentile bucket end up hitting at an insane rate.

Garrett Wilson is a cornerstone piece to your dynasty roster.

Jahan Dotson

WR • Washington Commanders

94.2%	93.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**13.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Brandin Cooks** **Elijah Moore** **Kendall Wright**

After the Big Three™ at wide receiver from last year's class, you hit some question marks.

It's not that Jahan Dotson is headed towards being irrelevant. Quite the opposite. A 93rd percentile Year 2 Model rating means that Dotson has about a 22% chance to score 16 or more points in either his second or third year. And there's almost a 50% chance that he'll score 14 or more points. That's what we've seen historically.

There's just some downside here. His 1.39 yards per route run rate was a bottom half number among worthwhile rookie wideouts over the last decade or so, and his targets per route run average was even worse. His 15.7% target share per game was fine, but nothing extraordinary.

The thing is, Dotson's been undervalued by the dynasty market since he entered the league. The Year 2 Model places him in a tier with guys like George Pickens, Christian Watson, and Treylon Burks — spoiler alert — but he often goes well after them in startup drafts. From *that* perspective, Dotson is sort of a buy candidate.

George Pickens

WR • Pittsburgh Steelers

82.5%	92.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**12.9**
Journey Comparables:	**Torrey Smith** **Chase Claypool** **Greg Little**

There are definitely George Pickens truthers out there, and while some of his highlight-reel catches were jaw-dropping during his rookie campaign, there are still some red flags to his overall profile.

When looking at his routes run and volume numbers, Pickens looks a whole lot like the aforementioned Jahan Dotson. He had nearly the exact same yards per route run, targets per route run, and target share per game rates.

One thing that’s helping Pickens is his rookie season yards per team pass attempt figure. The Steelers passing attack was pretty pitiful last season — especially during the first half of the year — so yards per team pass attempt is a way for us to see how well Pickens performed within the context of his offense. And he did well, with only 33 rookie wide receivers since 2011 faring better within the statistic.

Pickens has the tools to be a very good wide receiver in the NFL, but given his percentile rank and Journey Comparables, he doesn’t have a super great chance of being *elite*. Players in his Year 2 Model tier hit 18 or more PPR points in either Year 2 or Year 3 at just a 9% rate. Above the 95th percentile, that jumps up to 52%.

Because there are fantasy managers out there who think that ceiling is there for Pickens, it wouldn’t be a bad idea to shop him. If you can’t sell super high, holding onto him is fine. He should still be productive.

Christian Watson

WR • Green Bay Packers

83.5%	92.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**12.8**
Journey Comparables:	**Greg Little** **Chase Claypool** **DK Metcalf**

Just to reiterate, Journey Comparables only care about Z-Prospect and Year 2 Model scores. That's it. Because Christian Watson and the previously mentioned George Pickens have such similar ratings, their Journey Comparables are really similar, too.

Watson didn't have the most complete production profile entering the league last year, and the lack of early-declare status from a non-Power Five program made him even riskier. But the athleticism was there. And as I noted in last year's Watson writeup, sometimes that athleticism translates.

It did big time in 2022. Watson wasn't a full-time player until later in the season, but the dude thrived. He finished the year with a yards per route run rate of 2.26. Not only was that second-best in the class behind only Chris Olave, but among qualified rookie wideouts since 2011, it was seventh-highest. And the players around him on that list went on to have really productive careers.

Watson's 16.6% target share per game rate wasn't as high as you'd like to see, and that's what's scary about the potential for him to go the Chase Claypool route. His high-end Journey Comparable, DK Metcalf, was over 20% during his first year in the league, while Claypool wasn't.

So, in essence, we're close to where we were last offseason: Christian Watson is a high-ceiling pass-catcher who comes with a big reward. Per the Year 2 Model, he's a pretty decent bet for future production. And because of his peripherals, I'd argue he has a higher ceiling than George Pickens.

Treylon Burks

WR • Tennessee Titans

95.3%	91.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**13.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Rashod Bateman** **Corey Coleman** **Tavon Austin**

Rashod Bateman as the top Journey Comparable for Treylon Burks makes a ton of sense. He, like Burks, entered the league with a ton of dynasty managers thinking he could be *great.* And, like Burks, Bateman dealt with some injuries and didn't exactly live up to the hype.

Now, don't get me wrong: Burks had the more impressive rookie year. Behind the surface-level 8.6 PPR points per game average was a wideout with a respectable 1.75 yards per route run rate, a number fairly close to Garrett Wilson's. Burks also had a target share per game average of 17.3%, and that number looks even better when you focus on games where he saw significant snaps.

There were definitely moments last season where you could see the upside with Burks. His Year 2 Model score saw a dip, but that was bound to happen with the injuries he dealt with. The 90th to 95th percentile tier feels right. And that's objectively where he's at.

Wan'Dale Robinson

WR • New York Giants

92.6%	85.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**10.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Rondale Moore** **Kadarius Toney** **Jalen Reagor**

The Z-Prospect Model doesn't care a whole lot about wide receiver size. Or, I should say, it cares a lot more about collegiate production.

That's why the smaller Wan'Dale Robinson was still a 92nd to 93rd percentile wide receiver in the model after he was drafted in the second round last year. The draft capital was there, and Robinson's production at Kentucky was fantastic. Typically, if size is a huge concern, a player won't get drafted all that high. But Robinson was an early Day 2 pick.

Robinson was having a pretty underrated season before an ACL tear placed him on injured reserve. He averaged over a 17% target share per game rate, and his yards per route run was on par with Treylon Burks and Garrett Wilson. He just didn't get as much love because his season was similar to his height: short.

Rondale Moore as a top Journey Comparable for Robinson makes too much sense. Moore's played the majority of his snaps from the slot in the NFL, and, thus far, has made a living as a lower average depth of target player. Those types of players can be productive in fantasy, but we know there's typically a capped ceiling.

More often than not, a player in the 85th to 90th percentile will get you a double-digit PPR season in Year 2 or Year 3. Just don't expect a WR1 campaign.

Alec Pierce

WR • Indianapolis Colts

77.2%	84.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**9.7**
Journey Comparables:	**Michael Gallup** **Tajae Sharpe** **Jamison Crowder**

All things considered, it wasn't a bad first year for Alec Pierce. He improved on his prospect score thanks to a points per game average that was above seven, something we don't always see from his tier.

At the surface, his peripheral numbers don't look very strong. His yards per route run rate was an ordinary 1.24, his targets per route run rate of 0.16 was arguably even worse, and his 14.4% target share per game average was…fine.

On the plus side, it's tough to find a situation that was worse than Pierce's. The Colts had the second-lowest passing yards per attempt in the league last year, and it's not like other wide receivers in the offense dominated. Michael Pittman, for example, had a 1.44 yards per route run rate after getting to 1.95 the year prior. And Pierce's yards per route run was better than Parris Campbell's.

Pierce's Year 2 Model score ended up being better than expected, to be honest. His tier hasn't given us top-notch production consistently, but it's reassuring to know there've been some hits from the group in the past. The most notable one was another athletic freak in Chris Godwin.

Because the market is so down on Pierce, you could consider him a buy candidate. Why not see if things progress with a better offensive situation?

Romeo Doubs

WR • Green Bay Packers

66.0%	81.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**8.6**
Journey Comparables:	**Dede Westbrook** **Ace Sanders** **Darnell Mooney**

Romeo Doubs ended up being one of the pleasant surprises of the 2022 wide receiver class. He had just a 66th percentile Z-Prospect Score after getting selected in the fourth round, and the model liked him, giving Doubs a nice Draft Capital Delta.

He exceeded expectation as a rookie, but I'm not sure his profile screams "perennial fantasy football starter." He saw a far worse yards per route run rate than teammate Christian Watson last season, and it was below Randall Cobb's and Allen Lazard's, too. His 15.7% target share per game rate was solid for a rookie, but, again, it's not anything we haven't seen before.

Similar to Pierce, the market isn't expecting much from Doubs, so it's no big deal if you'd like to hold on. He's got Darnell Mooney as a Journey Comparable, showing us that there's some potential for his value to rise.

Tyquan Thornton

WR • New England Patriots

77.8%	77.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**7.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Stedman Bailey** **Leonard Hankerson** **Taywan Taylor**

No one liked the Tyquan Thornton selection by New England last season. The Z-Prospect Model didn't really love it, either, giving Thornton a -8.4% Draft Capital Delta. Thornton's collegiate production profile wasn't that bad. It just wasn't good enough to warrant a top-50 selection.

Leave it to the Patriots.

Thornton's score stayed pretty neutral year over year only because players in this grouping traditionally don't do a whole lot. If you peep the hit rate charts from earlier in the guide, wideouts under the 80th percentile mark in the Year 2 Model rarely give you juice in fantasy football. Thornton's still under that, and for good reason — his yards per route run rate was fourth-worst among 40-plus target rookie wide receivers since 2011.

Thornton looks like someone the fantasy community got right. And by that, I mean he's got a very, very small chance to be a significant contributor.

Jameson Williams

WR • Detroit Lions

95.1% Z-Prospect Score	76.8% Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.7**
Journey Comparables:	**Josh Doctson** **Mike Williams** **Jonathan Baldwin**

We ran into this issue in the Year 2 Model last season with Travis Etienne. You have a great prospect who barely plays as a rookie, and since the model is production-based, that player takes a big hit.

With that being said, I've got to at least state what the numbers say: Among the 49 Year 2 Model wide receivers in the 70th to 80th percentile, only two were able to give us a season in Year 2 or Year 3 with 10 or more PPR points per game.

If you've got Jameson Williams on your dynasty roster, that *should* make you a little nervous.

Fortunately, one of those players who broke free was Mike Williams, a Journey Comparable for Jameson (we're calling them by their first names now so no one is confused). Mike entered the NFL with a super high prospect score after being selected seventh overall, but he struggled early thanks to injury.

Sound familiar?

I'd likely not be aggressive in pursuing Williams because having a truly great season over the next two years is unlikely given history. At least he has the tools and ability to get there, and there's reason his Year 2 Model score is so low. You can't say that about the vast majority of wideouts who ranked similarly.

Skyy Moore

WR • Kansas City Chiefs

85.5%	76.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.7**
Journey Comparables:	**Andy Isabella** **DJ Chark** **Terrace Marshall**

Well, this seems fitting. I liked Andy Isabella when he entered the league. I liked Terrace Marshall when he entered the league. And I liked Skyy Moore when he entered the league.

Goodnight, sweet prince.

The odds that Skyy Moore becomes someone you love for fantasy purposes are slim. He scored just 2.7 PPR points per game as a rookie. He had a well below average yards per team pass attempt rate within an offense that lacked higher-end alternatives at wide receiver.

If you want to look at this more colorfully, his yards per route run rate was better than most other Chiefs wide receivers. And he led qualified KC wideouts in targets per route run. So maybe there's something there? Maybe?

Chances are — and it pains me to type this — there's not.

David Bell

WR • Cleveland Browns

81.8%	73.6%
Z-Prospect Score	Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Bryan Edwards** **Tyler Johnson** **Dyami Brown**

David Bell was a hyper-productive wideout coming out of Purdue last season. The Z-Prospect Model liked him more than NFL teams seemed to, giving him a strong Draft Capital Delta.

And a swing and a miss.

Bell had high-variance comparables entering the league, and it’s looking like the lower-end of his range of outcomes is going to hit. It’s quite similar to his top-two Journey Comparables – they’re guys with great collegiate analytical profiles who may not have gotten the draft capital the fantasy community wanted. Now, they’re toast.

I really wouldn’t expect a bounce-back of some sort from Bell. His 0.70 yards per route run rate is sixth-worst among 30-plus target rookie wideouts since 2011.

You know how many wide receivers have given fantasy managers sustained production with such low efficiency per route run since 2011?

None.

Closing

In college, I had a professor who would allow his students to bring a cheat sheet the size of a notecard to every exam. The night before a test, I'd fill that bad boy up with notes that seemed only readable through a magnifying glass.

I didn't know what I'd be answering on those tests. I just knew that the more information I had in front of me, the better off I'd be.

It's sort of like this prospect guide. Except instead of a notecard, **you get a PDF that's more than 130 pages long**.

The Z-Prospect Model, the Year 2 Model…they're not going to give you every answer to the rookie draft test. Like the college cheat sheet, the models are there for guidance. **They're providing you with a baseline**.

And it's a baseline that the majority of your leaguemates won't have.

As I retreat back into my parent's basement to improve my DPS skill rating in Overwatch, I want you to remember that.

This isn't about being flawless. It's about being better than the people you play fantasy football with.